THE ILIAD

ACT 1: THE WRATH & THE BROKEN TRUCE

Pride, Divine Retribution & The Gathering of Bronze

BOOK 1: THE RAGE OF ACHILLES & THE PLAGUES OF APOLLO

In the tenth year of the siege of Troy, Chryses, priest of Apollo, arrives at the Achaean camp bearing ransom for his daughter
Chryseis. Agamemnon spurns the priest with brutal insults. Apollo answers the priest's prayers by raining plague arrows upon the
Greek host for nine days. Achilles summons an assembly; when the seer Calchas reveals Agamemnon's guilt, a furious quarrel
erupts between Achilles and Agamemnon. Agamemnon surrenders Chryseis but seizes Achilles' war-prize Briseis. Achilles
withdraws his Myrmidons from the war, and his divine mother Thetis ascends Olympus to plead with Zeus to grant victory to the
Trojans until the Achaeans honor her son.

SCENE 1: THE TENT OF AGAMEMNON — THE BLACK SHIPS AT TROY — DAY

The salt surf hissed along the dark hulls of a thousand beached black ships. For nine long years, the sons of the
Achaeans had encamped upon the sands of the Troad, their timbers rotting, their linen cordage fraying under
the eastern sun. Smoke from bronze-smithies and grease from roasting sacrificial oxen drifted over the sprawling
sea-wall. Down the center avenue of tents walked an aged man clothed in spotless white linen, holding high in his
trembling hands a golden staff wreathed with the sacred laurel fillets of Apollo the Far-Darter.

Chryses knelt upon the damp sand before the council of bronze-clad kings, holding aloft sacks of beaten gold and electrum
cups: "Sons of Atreus, and all you well-greaved Achaeans! To you may the immortal gods who hold Olympus grant that you
sack the high citadel of Priam and make your return home in safety! But release to me my beloved daughter, fair Chryseis!
Accept this boundless ransom, and show reverent fear to Apollo, the son of Zeus who shoots from afar!"

The soldiers of the Danaans shouted in one roaring voice: "Honor the priest of the god! Take the glittering ransom and let the
maiden return to her father's hearth!"

Agamemnon stepped down from his carved ivory chair, his face blackened with fury: "Let me not find you lingering by our
hollow ships, old man, neither now nor coming back hereafter, lest the staff and laurel fillets of your god protect you not! As
for your daughter, I will not set her free! Old age shall seize her in our royal halls at Argos, far from her native land, working
the loom and serving my bed! Be gone! Provoke me no further, if you wish to carry your bones away alive!"

The old priest shrank back in terror. Alone he walked along the shore of the loud-sounding sea, weeping bitter tears, and
prayed into the foaming waves to Lord Apollo.

Phoebus Apollo said, "Down from the peaks of Olympus strode Apollo, wrath burning in his divine breast, his bow and
covered quiver rattling on his shoulders like hail as he moved. He sat down apart from the ships, and the clang of his silver
bow was terrible. First he shot the mules and the swift hounds; then day and night he aimed his biting arrows at the men, and
the funeral pyres of the dead burned ceaselessly across the sands."
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea,
Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.
Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a
warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be
ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"
Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love
you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold
your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to
follow our renown."
Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If
every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral
pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls
of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"
Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of
thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the

woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the
infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"
Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and
battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can
cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel
with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"
Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every
mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I
followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best
youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"
Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of
the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the
innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The evening smoke of sacrifices rose into the gathering twilight over the plain of Troy, where the bronze shields of the dead
lay half-buried in the dust like fallen leaves of autumn.
Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of
Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A
warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain
in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"
Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is
stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common
soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their
native homes again."

Upon the Scaean ramparts, Hector turned to his brother Paris: "Look down, Paris! Look upon the mounds of fresh earth
outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any
spark of our father Priam’s royal blood, stand in the front line tomorrow and let the bronze decide who is worthy of the sun!"
Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will
speak to the Argives! I will duel Menelaus before the two armies, and if I fall, Helen is his; but if my spear finds his breast,
let the Achaeans row their rotten ships back to the Peloponnese in shame!"
Andromache pressed infant Astyanax to her bosom, whispering: "O my little child, star of my heart! Your father fights for a
doomed city, and your mother has no fortress in the world except his arms! When his bronze helmet falls, who will protect
you from the spears of the merciless Danaans?"
Hector gently kissed the weeping child’s forehead: "Astyanax, do not fear your father’s horsehair crest! May the gods grant
that you grow taller and braver than Hector, to rule steep Ilium with justice and bring joy to your mother’s soul!"
The night descended over the ancient cradle of the Troad. In the palace of Priam, fifty fires burned on the marble terraces,
while across the plain the Achaean sentries leaned upon their spears, listening to the murmurs of the Trojan bivouac.
Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought
against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened
to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"
Agamemnon gripped his gold-banded staff: "Nestor, you speak words of truth, but this man Achilles wishes to be above all
others! He wishes to rule all, to lord it over all, and to give orders to all—which I think there is one here who will not obey! If
the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"
Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in
everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing
more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you
take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my
will!"
Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we

fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who
nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies
with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"
The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks
under the golden walls of their ancestral city.
King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first,
noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who
entertained him with loving friendship!"
Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus!
Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"
The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of
two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 2: THE GREAT COUNCIL OF WAR — THE QUARREL OF THE HEROES — DAY
For nine days the arrows of the god rained through the camp. On the tenth day, goddess white-armed Hera put it
into Achilles' mind to summon the army to an assembly. Thousands of warriors assembled in the dust, coughing,
hollow-eyed, leaning upon their ashen spears.
Achilles rose before the assembly, his bronze breastplate gleaming: "Son of Atreus, I fear we must turn our ships back and
flee across the wine-dark sea, if we can escape death at all, since war and pestilence together are crushing the Achaeans! Let
us consult some prophet, priest, or interpreter of dreams, who can tell us why Phoebus Apollo is so terribly enraged—whether
he blames us for a broken vow or a withheld hecatomb!"
Calchas stood with folded hands: "Achilles, beloved of Zeus, you ask me to speak the wrath of Apollo. I will speak, but swear
to me by your life that you will defend me with your hands and spear! For I know that my words will infuriate a king whose
word is law over all the Argives!"
Achilles struck his spear into the soil: "Speak out with bold heart, Calchas! For by Apollo whom you serve, as long as I live

and look upon the light of earth, no man among all the Danaans shall lay heavy hands upon you by our hollow ships—not
even if you name Agamemnon himself, who boasts to be far the mightiest of all the Achaeans!"
Calchas pointed toward Agamemnon: "It is for the sake of his priest that Apollo strikes us! Agamemnon dishonored Chryses,
refused the ransom, and kept the daughter! The god will not lift this foul pestilence from the Danaans until we restore the
bright-eyed girl to her father without price or ransom, and lead a sacred hecatomb to Chryse!"
Agamemnon sprang up, his dark heart filling with fury, his eyes like blazing coals: "Prophet of evil! Never yet have you
spoken a favorable word to me! Always your heart delights in prophesying doom! I loved Chryseis better than Clytemnestra,
my wedded wife, for she is not inferior to her in form, mind, or handiwork! Yet even so, I will give her back if that is best; I
desire the people to be saved, not to perish! But prepare for me another prize immediately, that I alone among the Argives
may not go without a prize, which would be unseemly!"
Achilles glared with pure disgust: "Most glorious son of Atreus, most covetous of all living men! How shall the high-hearted
Achaeans give you a prize now? The plunder from the cities we have sacked has already been apportioned; it is shameful to
demand the soldiers to heap it up anew! Give the girl back to the god, and we Achaeans will repay you three and fourfold
when Zeus grants us to sack the walled city of Troy!"
Agamemnon sneered: "Do not try to outwit me, godlike Achilles! Do you think to keep your own prize while I sit
empty-handed? If the generous Achaeans give me a prize equal to my rank, so be it! But if they will not, I will come myself
and seize your prize, or the prize of Ajax, or Odysseus, and haul her away! And whoever I visit shall be left to burn with rage!
But we will settle this hereafter! Now launch a black ship, put aboard the maiden Chryseis, and let one of our
counselors—Ajax, Idomeneus, or Odysseus—sail as captain!"
Achilles' hand dropped to the silver hilt of his great sword, half-drawing the bronze blade from its sheath: "You shameless
dog! Cloaked in insolence, greedy for gain! The Trojans never did me any wrong; they never drove off my cattle or destroyed
my crops in fertile Phthia, for between us lie shadowy mountains and the sounding sea! It was for your sake, you dog-faced
wretch, that we sailed here, to win redress for Menelaus and for you! And now you threaten to strip me of the prize for which
I labored and bled! I am going home to Phthia! It is better to return with my curved ships than to stay here without honor,
piling up wealth for a tyrant!"

Athena caught Achilles by his golden hair, her gray eyes flashing terribly: "I have come down from heaven to stay your fury,
if you will obey! White-armed Hera sent me, who loves and pities you both in her heart. Check your sword; do not draw the
blade! Lash him with words instead, for thus I promise you: the day will come when threefold gifts of shining bronze and
gold will be laid at your feet to atone for this insult! Obey us!"
Achilles pushed his heavy sword back into its sheath: "Goddess, a man must observe the word of you two, even though his
heart is bursting with rage. He who heeds the gods is heard by them in turn." Then turning to Agamemnon, he hurled the
gold-studded scepter to the earth: "You drunkard, with the eyes of a dog and the heart of a deer! Never have you dared arm
yourself for battle with your people, nor go out with the chieftains for an ambush! That seems like death to you! By this
scepter, which shall never put forth leaves or twigs again, I swear a great oath: the day will come when a yearning for
Achilles will seize all the sons of the Achaeans! And in that day you will be powerless to help them, though you tear your
heart out within you in rage that you showed no honor to the best of the Achaeans!"
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
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arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 3: THE PEAK OF OLYMPUS — THETIS AND ZEUS — DAWN
Briseis was led weeping from Achilles' tent by the heralds Talthybius and Eurybates. Achilles sat weeping apart
from his companions upon the shore of the grey sea, his hands outstretched over the boundless waters, crying out
to his mother.
Thetis rose from the white foam like a mist, sitting beside her weeping son and stroking his hair: "Why do you weep, my

child? What sorrow has touched your heart? Speak, hide it not in your mind, that we both may know!"
Achilles groaned: "You know it all, mother! Agamemnon has dishonored me, taking my war-prize Briseis with his own
hands! If you have any power, mother, ascend to Olympus! Grasp the knees of Cronus' son Zeus! Remind him how you alone
among the immortals saved him when Hera, Poseidon, and Pallas Athena sought to bind him in chains! Beg him to hem the
Achaeans in against their black ships and slaughter them along the sea, that they may all reap the reward of their king!"
At dawn, silver-footed Thetis rose through the clouds to the highest crag of Mount Olympus. She found the son of Cronus
sitting apart from all the other gods. She dropped to the marble floor, grasping his knees with her left hand and holding his
chin with her right.
Thetis looked up into the terrible eyes of Zeus: "Father Zeus, if ever I helped you in word or deed among the immortals,
fulfill my prayer! Honor my son, who is doomed to the swiftest death of all mortal men! Agamemnon has robbed him of his
prize! Grant victory to the Trojans, Lord of Olympus, until the Achaeans render honor to my son and exalt him with glory!"
Zeus groaned deeply: "This is a disastrous business! You will set me at war with Hera, who already taunts me before the
immortals, accusing me of favoring the Trojans in battle! Go now, lest she see you; leave this to my care. See, I will nod with
my head to bind my word, for among the immortals my nod is the greatest pledge: it cannot be revoked, nor deceive, nor fail
of its fulfillment!"
The son of Cronus bowed his dark brows. The ambrosial curls tumbled forward from the sovereign's immortal head, and all
vast Olympus trembled to its foundations.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 2: THE DECEIVING DREAM, THERSITES & THE MUSTERING OF THE HOST

Zeus sends a Deceiving Dream to Agamemnon, falsely promising that he will capture Troy this very day. Agamemnon decides to test
the morale of his army by proposing an immediate voyage home to Greece; to his horror, the weary soldiers break rank and
stampede toward the ships. Odysseus, inspired by Athena, rallies the chieftains and brutally silences the insolent commoner
Thersites. Nestor restores order, and the Achaean host is marshaled in glittering bronze ranks across the plain of the Scamander.

SCENE 4: THE ROYAL PAVILION — THE DECEIVING DREAM — NIGHT

All other gods and men slept soundly through the night, but sweet sleep held not Zeus. In his mind he pondered
how he might bring honor to Achilles and destroy multitudes beside the Danaan ships. He summoned the
Phantom of False Dreams.

Zeus spoke into the shadows: "Fly, destructive Dream, down to the swift ships of the Achaeans! Enter the tent of
Agamemnon and bid him arm the long-haired Achaeans in all haste, for now he may capture the wide-wayed city of the
Trojans! The immortals on Olympus no longer differ in council; Hera has bent them all to her will, and sorrow is poised over
the Trojans!"

The Dream flew down, hovering over Agamemnon’s head in the likeness of ancient Nestor. Agamemnon awoke with a start,
the divine voice still ringing in his ears, believing in his blind arrogance that Troy would fall before sundown.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea,
Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.

Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a
warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be

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Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
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arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 5: THE SEASHORE — THE STAMPEDE & THERSITES' DEFIANCE — MORNING
To test the temper of his men, Agamemnon proclaimed to the assembled soldiers that nine years had passed,
their ships were rotten, and it was time to abandon the war and sail for Greece. With a roar like ocean breakers,
the thousands of weary soldiers broke ranks and stampeded toward the black ships, dragging down the props
and clearing the launching trenches.
Odysseus took the immortal scepter of Agamemnon and ran along the beach, blocking the soldiers: "Halt, madmen! You
know not yet the mind of the son of Atreus! He is merely testing the army! The rule of many is no good thing; let there be
one ruler, one king, to whom the son of crooked-counseling Cronus gave the scepter!"
Thersites, bow-legged, bandy-shouldered, with a pointed skull tufted with scruffy hair, shrieked at Agamemnon: "What do
you lack now, son of Atreus? Your tents are full of bronze and the choicest women whom we Achaeans give you first of all!
Do you thirst for more gold, which some Trojan horse-tamer will bring as ransom for his son whom I or another warrior have
captured? Soft cowards, women of Achaea, men no more! Let us sail home and leave this greedy monarch to gorge on his
prizes alone in Troy, that he may learn whether we are of any help to him or not!"

Odysseus strode up to him, eyes blazing with fury, and struck Thersites across the back and shoulders with the heavy
gold-studded scepter. A bloody welt rose upon the man's skin; tears fell from his eyes, and he sat down terrified, wiping
away his tears while the soldiers laughed despite their misery.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 6: THE PLAIN OF SCAMANDER — THE CATALOGUE OF THE HOST — NOON
Homeric Rhapsode (Narrator) said, "Tell me now, Muses, who have your dwellings on Olympus—for you are
goddesses, and are present, and know all things, while we hear only rumors and know nothing: who were the
captains and lords of the Danaans? The multitude I could not tell or name, not even if ten tongues were mine and
ten mouths, an unwearied voice, and a heart of bronze within me!"
As when devouring fire blazes through an endless forest on a mountain peak, and the glare shines afar through the heavens,
so from the glittering bronze of the marching armies the blinding sheen flashed through the sky. Thousands poured onto the
Scamandrian plain, countless as leaves and flowers in the season of spring.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I
followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best
youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"
Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of
the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the
innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
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the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The evening smoke of sacrifices rose into the gathering twilight over the plain of Troy, where the bronze shields of the dead
lay half-buried in the dust like fallen leaves of autumn.
Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of

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warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain
in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"
Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is
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soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their
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outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any
spark of our father Priam’s royal blood, stand in the front line tomorrow and let the bronze decide who is worthy of the sun!"
Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will
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to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"

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the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"
Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in
everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing
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Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus!
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The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 3: THE DUEL OF MENELAUS AND PARIS & HELEN ON THE SCAEAN WALLS

As the two armies advance, Paris leaps forward to challenge the best of the Achaeans, but quails when Menelaus steps forth. Hector
shames Paris for his cowardice. Paris agrees to duel Menelaus in single combat to decide the possession of Helen and end the war.
King Priam is summoned to seal the oaths with blood sacrifice. Upon the Scaean Gate, Helen identifies the great Achaean
champions for Priam. In the duel, Menelaus shatters his sword on Paris' helmet and drags him by his horsehair crest, but Aphrodite
snaps the chinstrap and spirits Paris away in a cloud of mist to his perfumed bedchamber in Troy.
SCENE 7: NO-MAN'S-LAND — PARIS' CHALLENGE & HECTOR'S REPROACH — DAY
The Trojans advanced with screaming cries like cranes fleeing the winter storm, but the Achaeans marched in
grim silence, breathing courage, their bronze shields locked wall-to-wall. Out from the Trojan ranks stepped
prince Alexandros, beautiful as a god, wearing a leopard-skin on his shoulders and brandishing two
bronze-tipped spears.
Menelaus leaped from his war chariot, his armor clattering: "At last! As a starving lion rejoices when he finds a stag with
great antlers, so my heart rejoices! Today the seducer shall pay for the honor of Sparta!"
When Paris saw Menelaus stride forward, his heart failed him. As a man starts back in fear when he sees a venomous viper in
a mountain glen, his knees shaking and paleness seizing his cheeks, so Paris slunk back into the crowd of Trojan warriors.
Hector blocked Paris with his spear: "Evil Paris, fair of form, mad after women, deceiver! Would that you had never been
born, or had died unwed! Truly the long-haired Achaeans laugh aloud, thinking you a champion because of your beauty,
when there is no strength or courage in your heart! Was it such a man as you who sailed the deep sea, stole a lovely woman
from her husband's house, and brought this curse upon your father, your city, and your people? Can you not face Menelaus?
You would learn what kind of man he is whose blossoming wife you hold! Your lyre will not help you then, nor the gifts of
Aphrodite, nor your flowing hair, when you lie rolled in the dust!"
Paris lowered his head: "Hector, your reproach is just; your heart is unyielding as an ax that cuts the timber. Do not mock the
lovely gifts of golden Aphrodite. But if you wish me to fight, seat the Trojans and Achaeans upon the ground! Set Menelaus
and me in the midst to duel for Helen and all her wealth! Whoever proves the better man, let him take the woman and the
treasure home, while the rest swear oaths of peace!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.

Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

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Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and

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Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of
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The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks

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King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first,
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 8: THE SCAEAN GATE — HELEN AND PRIAM (TEICHOSCOPIA) — DAY
Upon the Scaean Gate sat the elders of Troy, like cicadas upon a tree sending forth their sweet lily voices. When
they saw Helen coming toward the tower in her shimmering white veil, they murmured softly to one another:
"Small wonder that Trojans and Achaeans should suffer long years of agony for such a woman! Terribly does
she resemble the immortal goddesses in face! Yet even so, let her depart on the ships, that she may not leave
sorrow behind for us and our children!"

Priam beckoned with his hand: "Come sit by me, dear child, that you may see your former husband, your kinsmen, and your
friends! I do not hold you to blame; the gods alone are to blame, who brought upon me this tearful war with the Achaeans!
Tell me, who is that mighty hero, so tall and noble among the Argives?"
Helen wept softly behind her veil: "Venerable father, dear to me and terrible! Would that vile death had pleased me on the day
I followed your son here, abandoning my bridal chamber, my little child Hermione, and my sweet companions! But that was
not to be, and so I pine away in weeping! That man is the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, both a noble king and a
valiant spearman; brother-in-law was he to shameless me, if ever such a creature existed!"
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the

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The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 9: THE DUELING GROUND & THE PERFUMED CHAMBER — AFTERNOON
Sacred oaths were sworn, the wine poured from golden flagons, and lots shaken in Hector’s bronze helmet. Paris
cast his long spear first, striking Menelaus’ round shield, but the bronze point bent. Menelaus prayed to Zeus,
hurling his spear clean through Paris’ shield and corselet, tearing his tunic.
Drawing his silver-studded sword, Menelaus brought it crashing down upon the horn of Paris’ helmet, but the blade shattered
into four pieces! Roaring in frustration, Menelaus seized Paris by his horsehair crest, turning him around and dragging him
toward the Achaean lines, choking him with the embroidered ox-hide strap.
Aphrodite said, "Goddess Aphrodite snapped the tough ox-hide strap like thread! Leaving the empty bronze helmet in
Menelaus’ fist, she snatched Paris away in a thick purple cloud and set him down in his fragrant, perfumed bedchamber in the
palace of Troy."
Entering the bedchamber, Helen looked upon Paris reclining on his couch: "You have come back from the battle? Would that
you had perished there, felled by that mighty warrior who was my former husband! You used to boast that you were his better
in strength and spear! Go challenge Menelaus again! But no—stay here, lest his bronze spear strike you down in your
shame!"
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea,

Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.
Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a
warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be
ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love
you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold
your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to
follow our renown."
Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If
every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral
pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls
of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"
Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of
thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the
woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the
infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"
Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and
battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can
cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel
with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"
Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every
mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I
followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best
youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"

Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of
the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the
innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The evening smoke of sacrifices rose into the gathering twilight over the plain of Troy, where the bronze shields of the dead
lay half-buried in the dust like fallen leaves of autumn.
Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of
Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A
warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain
in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"
Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is
stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common
soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their
native homes again."
Upon the Scaean ramparts, Hector turned to his brother Paris: "Look down, Paris! Look upon the mounds of fresh earth
outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any
spark of our father Priam’s royal blood, stand in the front line tomorrow and let the bronze decide who is worthy of the sun!"

Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will
speak to the Argives! I will duel Menelaus before the two armies, and if I fall, Helen is his; but if my spear finds his breast,
let the Achaeans row their rotten ships back to the Peloponnese in shame!"
Andromache pressed infant Astyanax to her bosom, whispering: "O my little child, star of my heart! Your father fights for a
doomed city, and your mother has no fortress in the world except his arms! When his bronze helmet falls, who will protect
you from the spears of the merciless Danaans?"
Hector gently kissed the weeping child’s forehead: "Astyanax, do not fear your father’s horsehair crest! May the gods grant

that you grow taller and braver than Hector, to rule steep Ilium with justice and bring joy to your mother’s soul!"
The night descended over the ancient cradle of the Troad. In the palace of Priam, fifty fires burned on the marble terraces,
while across the plain the Achaean sentries leaned upon their spears, listening to the murmurs of the Trojan bivouac.
Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought
against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened
to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"
Agamemnon gripped his gold-banded staff: "Nestor, you speak words of truth, but this man Achilles wishes to be above all
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the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"
Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in
everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing
more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you
take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my
will!"
Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we
fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who
nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies
with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"
The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks
under the golden walls of their ancestral city.
King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first,
noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who
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Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus!
Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"
The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of

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arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 4: THE SHATTERED TRUCE & THE CLASHING BRONZE

On Olympus, Zeus taunts Hera by proposing that Menelaus be declared the victor and Troy spared. Enraged, Hera demands the
total destruction of Troy. Zeus yields, sending Athena down to shatter the truce. Disguised as a Trojan warrior, Athena convinces
the foolish archer Pandarus to shoot an arrow at Menelaus. The arrow wounds Menelaus, drawing blood. The sacred truce is
destroyed. Agamemnon marshals the Greek chieftains—praising Idomeneus and Ajax, testing Diomedes and Odysseus. The two
massive armies collide in an explosion of clashing shields, flying spears, and dying screams.

SCENE 10: MOUNT OLYMPUS & THE TROJAN RANKS — DAY

Hera's eyes flashed with venom: "Dread son of Cronus, what word have you spoken? How can you make my toil
vain and of no effect, the sweat I sweated in the labor of summoning the host to crush Priam and his sons? Do as
you will, but we other gods do not all approve!"

Zeus sighed heavily: "Strange goddess! What vast wrongs have Priam and his sons done you that you rage incessantly to sack
the well-built walls of Ilium? Go then! Let Athena descend and incite the Trojans to break the sworn oaths first!"

Athena shot down like a blazing meteor. Approaching Pandarus, son of Lycaon, she whispered foolish pride into his mind.

Pandarus strung his polished wild-goat horn bow, drew the bowstring to his nipple and the iron notch to the horn, and let fly.

The arrow whistled through the air, piercing Menelaus' golden belt and drawing dark crimson blood.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
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arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 11: THE GREEK LINES — AGAMEMNON’S FURY & EPITHELESIS — DAY
Agamemnon held Menelaus’ hand as the physician Machaon extracted the barbed arrow: "Dear brother! It was
your death I sealed when I swore the truce! But the solemn oaths shall not be in vain—not the blood of lambs,
not the unmixed wine, not the clasped right hands! Even if Zeus does not fulfill them this day, he will fulfill them
at last, and the violators will pay with their lives, their wives, and their children! For well I know this in heart
and soul: a day will come when sacred Ilium shall fall, and Priam of the good ashen spear, and the people of
Priam!"
Agamemnon strode through the ranks of warriors. Finding Diomedes standing beside his chariot, he tested the young prince:
"Son of battle-hearted Tydeus, why do you stand cowering here looking upon the rifts of war? That was not your father’s
way!"
Diomedes (Tydides) said, "Diomedes answered not a word, revering the rebuke of the revered king. But he leaped fully
armored from his chariot to the ground, and the bronze clanged so fiercely upon the prince’s breast that fear would have
seized even a stout-hearted warrior."

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"
The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks
under the golden walls of their ancestral city.
King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first,
noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who
entertained him with loving friendship!"

Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus!
Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"
The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of
two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 12: THE CLASHING FRONTLINE — TOTAL WAR COMMENCES — AFTERNOON

As when two winter torrents flowing down from the mountains join their waters in a gorge, roaring from mighty
springs within a hollow ravine, and afar off a shepherd hears the thunder in the hills, so from the clash of the
armies arose screaming terror and shouts of triumph. Ox-hide shields bashed against ox-hide shields, bronze
spears shattered against breastplates, and the red earth ran with blood.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea,
Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.
Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a
warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be
ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"
Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love
you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold
your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to
follow our renown."
Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If
every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral
pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls
of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"
Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of
thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the
woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the

infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"
Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and
battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can
cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel
with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"

Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every
mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I
followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best
youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"
Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of
the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the
innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The evening smoke of sacrifices rose into the gathering twilight over the plain of Troy, where the bronze shields of the dead
lay half-buried in the dust like fallen leaves of autumn.
Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of
Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A
warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain
in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"
Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is
stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common
soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their
native homes again."
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outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any
spark of our father Priam’s royal blood, stand in the front line tomorrow and let the bronze decide who is worthy of the sun!"
Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will
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to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"
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the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"

Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in
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arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 5: THE ARISTEIA OF DIOMEDES & THE WOUNDING OF GODS

Athena fills Diomedes with superhuman strength, causing fire to blaze from his helmet and shield. She removes the mortal mist from
his eyes, commanding him to avoid all gods except Aphrodite. Diomedes slaughters Trojan heroes across the plain. When Pandarus
wounds him with an arrow, Diomedes kills Pandarus with a spear through his face. Aeneas rushes to protect the corpse; Diomedes
crushes Aeneas' hip with an enormous boulder. Aphrodite flies down to shield her son Aeneas; Diomedes charges the goddess,
wounding her wrist. Ares takes the field; with Athena's guidance, Diomedes drives his bronze spear into the belly of the God of War,
sending Ares howling back to Olympus.

SCENE 13: THE PLAIN OF TROY — ATHENA EMPOWERS DIOMEDES — DAY

Pallas Athena bestowed on Tydeus' son Diomedes strength and boldness. She kindled unwearied flame from his
bronze helmet and shield, like the autumn star that shines brightest of all when bathed in Oceanus. Through the
thickest press of combat he charged like an overflowing river that sweeps away dikes and orchards.

Athena touched his eyes: "Courage, Diomedes! I have put the fearless might of your father Tydeus into your chest! And I
have lifted from your eyes the mortal mist that once hung over them, that you may distinguish god from mortal! If any god
comes testing you, do not fight against the immortals—except if Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, enters the battle: strike her with
the sharp bronze!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

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arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 14: THE SLAYING OF PANDARUS & WOUNDING OF APHRODITE — AFTERNOON
Pandarus hurled his spear, piercing Diomedes' shield, boasting of his kill. But Diomedes cast his spear; guided by
Athena, it struck Pandarus beside the nose, passed through his white teeth, severed the tongue at its root, and
came out beneath his jaw. The archer fell clattering from his chariot in the dust.
Aeneas sprang down with shield and spear to guard the body. Diomedes lifted in his bare hands a boulder such as two men of
our generation could not lift, and hurled it against Aeneas' hip, crushing the bone and tearing the sinews. As Aeneas sank to
his knees into black darkness, his divine mother Aphrodite threw her white arms around him, spreading her gleaming veil to
shield him from arrows.
Diomedes leaped forward with his spear: "Yield, daughter of Zeus! Withdraw from the war! Is it not enough that you beguile
feeble women? If you meddle with battle, I think you will shudder at the very name of war!"
Diomedes lunged, thrusting with the bronze point. The spear pierced the immortal veil woven by the Graces, slashing the
flesh of her palm. Out poured the immortal blood of the gods—the sacred ichor. Aphrodite shrieked aloud, dropped her son,
and fled to the heavens weeping.

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the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who
nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies
with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"
The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks
under the golden walls of their ancestral city.
King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first,
noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who
entertained him with loving friendship!"

Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus!
Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"
The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of
two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 5: THE ROUT OF ARES — THE BATTLEFIELD & OLYMPUS — TWILIGHT

Ares, god of slaughter, entered the field in a shroud of black cloud, slaughtering the Argives beside Hector.
Athena mounted Diomedes' war chariot, making the axle of beech groan beneath the weight of an immortal
goddess and the mightiest of mortals.
Ares lunged with his bronze spear to slaughter Diomedes, but Athena caught the point and turned it aside. Then Diomedes
shouted his war-cry and drove his bronze spear forward. Guided by the goddess, the spear tore deep into the lower belly of
Ares, ripping the flesh. Ares bellowed with a roar like nine or ten thousand warriors clashing in battle! Both armies shook
with terror as the God of War rose like a black storm cloud into the heavens.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea,
Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.
Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a
warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man's life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be
ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus' son!"
Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles' broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love
you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold
your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to
follow our renown."
Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If
every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral
pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls
of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"

Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of
thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the
woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the
infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"

Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and
battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can
cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel
with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"
Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every
mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I
followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best
youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"
Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of
the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the
innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The evening smoke of sacrifices rose into the gathering twilight over the plain of Troy, where the bronze shields of the dead
lay half-buried in the dust like fallen leaves of autumn.
Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of
Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A
warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain
in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"
Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is

stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common
soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their
native homes again."
Upon the Scaean ramparts, Hector turned to his brother Paris: "Look down, Paris! Look upon the mounds of fresh earth
outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any
spark of our father Priam’s royal blood, stand in the front line tomorrow and let the bronze decide who is worthy of the sun!"
Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will
speak to the Argives! I will duel Menelaus before the two armies, and if I fall, Helen is his; but if my spear finds his breast,
let the Achaeans row their rotten ships back to the Peloponnese in shame!"
Andromache pressed infant Astyanax to her bosom, whispering: "O my little child, star of my heart! Your father fights for a
doomed city, and your mother has no fortress in the world except his arms! When his bronze helmet falls, who will protect
you from the spears of the merciless Danaans?"
Hector gently kissed the weeping child’s forehead: "Astyanax, do not fear your father’s horsehair crest! May the gods grant
that you grow taller and braver than Hector, to rule steep Ilium with justice and bring joy to your mother’s soul!"
The night descended over the ancient cradle of the Troad. In the palace of Priam, fifty fires burned on the marble terraces,
while across the plain the Achaean sentries leaned upon their spears, listening to the murmurs of the Trojan bivouac.
Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought
against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened
to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"

Agamemnon gripped his gold-banded staff: "Nestor, you speak words of truth, but this man Achilles wishes to be above all
others! He wishes to rule all, to lord it over all, and to give orders to all—which I think there is one here who will not obey! If
the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"
Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in
everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing

more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you
take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my
will!"
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 6: HECTOR RETURNS TO TROY & THE PARTING OF HECTOR AND ANDROMACHE

With the gods driven from the field, the Achaeans push the Trojans back. Helenus counsels Hector to return to the city and
command Queen Hecuba and the matrons to offer a robe and sacrifice to Athena. On the battlefield, Glaucus and Diomedes
discover their ancestral guest-friendship, refusing to fight and exchanging golden armor for bronze. In Troy, Hector visits Hecuba,
rebukes Paris into arming himself, and finds his wife Andromache at the Scaean Gate holding their infant son Astyanax. In one of
the most moving scenes in world literature, Hector removes his terrifying helmet to embrace his laughing child, prays for his son's
future, and bids a heartbreaking farewell to his weeping wife.

SCENE 16: NO-MAN'S-LAND — GLAUCUS AND DIOMEDES — DAY

Diomedes lowered his spear: "Who are you, best of men, among mortal humans? Never before have I seen you in
the glorious fight, yet now you stand ahead of all! If you are mortal, know that the children of unhappy fathers
face my might!"

Glaucus answered with timeless majesty: "Great-hearted son of Tydeus, why ask my lineage? Like the leaves that fall upon
the ground, such are the generations of mortal men! The wind scatters the leaves on the earth, and the wood budding puts
forth others in the springtime. So one generation of men flourishes, and another fades away. But if you wish to know, my
ancestor Bellerophon rode the winged horse Pegasus and killed the Chimaera!"

Diomedes planted his spear in the earth with a broad smile: "Then you are my guest-friend from our fathers' days! Oeneus
my grandfather entertained blameless Bellerophon in his halls for twenty days! Let us avoid each other's spears through the
press of war! Let us exchange our armor, that both armies may know we boast to be guest-friends from of old!"

They leaped from their chariots, clasped each other's hands, and exchanged armor. Then Zeus stole Glaucus' wits away, for
he traded armor of gold worth a hundred oxen for armor of bronze worth nine.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea,
Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.
Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a
warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be
ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"
Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
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you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold
your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to
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Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If
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thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the
woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the
infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"
Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and
battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can
cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel
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mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I

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the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the
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Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A
warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain
in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"
Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is
stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common
soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their
native homes again."
Upon the Scaean ramparts, Hector turned to his brother Paris: "Look down, Paris! Look upon the mounds of fresh earth
outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any
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Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will
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Hector gently kissed the weeping child’s forehead: "Astyanax, do not fear your father’s horsehair crest! May the gods grant
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The night descended over the ancient cradle of the Troad. In the palace of Priam, fifty fires burned on the marble terraces,
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Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought
against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened
to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"
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the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"
Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 17: THE PALACE OF PARIS — HECTOR'S REBUKE — AFTERNOON
Hector entered the magnificent palace of Alexandros, holding his eleven-cubit spear tipped with flashing bronze
and a golden ring. He found Paris sitting with Helen, polishing his curved bow, breastplate, and shield.
Hector struck his spear upon the stone floor: "Strange man! It is not honorable to nurse this sullen wrath in your heart while
our people are perishing around the walls of the city! Because of you, the roar of war blazes around Troy! Up, before the
whole citadel is consumed with blazing fire!"
Paris rose with a light smile: "Hector, you reproach me justly and not beyond measure. It was not anger against the Trojans
that kept me here, but sorrow. But now my wife has urged me with gentle words to return to battle. Wait while I strap on my
bronze armor, or go ahead and I will overtake you!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in
everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing
more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you
take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my
will!"
Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we
fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who
nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies
with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"
The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks
under the golden walls of their ancestral city.
King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first,
noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who
entertained him with loving friendship!"

Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus!
Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"
The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of
two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and

arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 18: THE SCAEAN GATE — THE FAREWELL OF HECTOR AND ANDROMACHE — DUSK

As Hector hastened toward the Scaean Gate to return to the battlefield, his wife Andromache came running to meet him, accompanied by a nurse carrying upon her bosom their little son Astyanax, lovely as a morning star.

Andromache clutched Hector’s hand, tears streaming down her face.

Andromache pressed her face against his bronze armor: "Dearest husband, your own courage will destroy you! Have you no pity for your infant son, or for unhappy me who will soon be your widow? For soon the Achaeans will rush upon you and slay you! If I lose you, it would be better for me to go down beneath the earth, for no comfort will remain when you meet your doom, only sorrow! Achilles slew my father Eetion, sacked Thebe, and slew my seven brothers in a single day! Hector, you are father to me now, and noble mother, and brother, and my shining husband! Have pity on us! Stay here upon the tower, that you may not make your child an orphan and your wife a widow!"

Great Hector of the gleaming helmet answered: "All these things are in my mind too, my wife. But I should feel deep shame before the Trojans and the long-robed women of Troy if like a coward I shrank from the battle! My soul forbids it, for I have learned to be brave always and to fight in the forefront of the Trojans, winning glory for my father and for myself! For well I know this in my heart: the day will come when sacred Ilium shall fall, and Priam, and the people of Priam! But not the grief of the Trojans, nor of Hecuba, nor of King Priam grieves me so much as the thought of you, when some bronze-clad Achaean leads you away weeping, having stripped you of your day of freedom, to work the loom for a foreign mistress in Argos! And someone seeing your tears will say: 'Look at the wife of Hector, who was the bravest warrior of the horse-taming Trojans when they fought for Troy!' But may the heaped-up earth cover my dead body before I hear your screams as you are dragged away into slavery!"

Hector reached out his arms to his little son. But the child shrank back screaming against the nurse’s breast, terrified at the sight of his father, frightened by the bronze breastplate and the horsehair crest nodding terribly from the peak of the helmet.

Both father and mother laughed through their tears.

Hector took the gleaming helmet from his head and placed it upon the ground. Then he kissed his beloved son, tossed him in his arms, and prayed aloud to Zeus and the immortal gods.

Hector lifted the boy to the evening sky: "Zeus, and all you gods! Grant that this boy, my son, may become like me, pre-eminent among the Trojans, mighty in strength, and rule with power over Ilium! And may men say of him as he returns

from battle: 'This man is far braver than his father!' And may he bring back blood-stained spoils from slain enemies, and
delight his mother’s heart!"
He placed the child back into his wife’s arms. Andromache pressed him to her fragrant bosom, smiling through her tears.
Hector pitied her, stroking her cheek with his hand.

Hector whispered softly: "Dear heart, do not grieve too deeply. No man shall send me down to Hades before my appointed
hour; and fate, I tell you, no mortal man has ever escaped, whether coward or brave, from the day of his birth. Go home, look
to your own tasks, the loom and the distaff, and bid your handmaids set to work. War shall be the business of all men born in
Ilium, and most of all of me."
Hector lifted his horsehair-crested helmet from the dust. Andromache turned homeward, weeping bitter tears, constantly
looking back over her shoulder as Hector and Paris strode out into the plains of bronze.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea,
Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle.
Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a
warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be
ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"
Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King
of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love
you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold
your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to
follow our renown."
Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If

every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral
pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls
of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"
Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of
thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the
woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the
infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"
Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and
battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can
cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel
with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"
Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every
mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I
followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best
youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"
Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of
the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the
innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The evening smoke of sacrifices rose into the gathering twilight over the plain of Troy, where the bronze shields of the dead
lay half-buried in the dust like fallen leaves of autumn.
Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of
Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A

warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain
in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"
Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is
stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common
soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their
native homes again."
Upon the Scaean ramparts, Hector turned to his brother Paris: "Look down, Paris! Look upon the mounds of fresh earth
outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any
spark of our father Priam’s royal blood, stand in the front line tomorrow and let the bronze decide who is worthy of the sun!"
Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will
speak to the Argives! I will duel Menelaus before the two armies, and if I fall, Helen is his; but if my spear finds his breast,
let the Achaeans row their rotten ships back to the Peloponnese in shame!"
Andromache pressed infant Astyanax to her bosom, whispering: "O my little child, star of my heart! Your father fights for a
doomed city, and your mother has no fortress in the world except his arms! When his bronze helmet falls, who will protect
you from the spears of the merciless Danaans?"
Hector gently kissed the weeping child’s forehead: "Astyanax, do not fear your father’s horsehair crest! May the gods grant
that you grow taller and braver than Hector, to rule steep Ilium with justice and bring joy to your mother’s soul!"
The night descended over the ancient cradle of the Troad. In the palace of Priam, fifty fires burned on the marble terraces,
while across the plain the Achaean sentries leaned upon their spears, listening to the murmurs of the Trojan bivouac.
Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought
against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened
to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"
Agamemnon gripped his gold-banded staff: "Nestor, you speak words of truth, but this man Achilles wishes to be above all
others! He wishes to rule all, to lord it over all, and to give orders to all—which I think there is one here who will not obey! If
the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"
Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in

everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing
more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you
take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my
will!"
Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we
fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who
nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies
with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"

The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks
under the golden walls of their ancestral city.
King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first,
noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who
entertained him with loving friendship!"
Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus!
Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"
The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of
two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

ACT 2: THE DUELS & THE DESPERATE EMBASSY

Single Combat, Cosmic Balances & The Rejection of Glory

BOOK 7: THE SINGLE COMBAT OF HECTOR AND GREAT AJAX

Inspired by Apollo and Athena, Hector halts the general engagement and challenges the champion of the Achaeans to single
combat. When the Greeks hesitate in dread, nine heroes step forward; the lot falls upon Telamonian Ajax. The two giants fight a
brutal duel until nightfall, shattering shields with boulders and trading spear-thrusts. Heralds part them as darkness falls. Hector
and Ajax part in noble mutual respect, exchanging gifts: Hector gives his silver-studded sword, and Ajax his purple war-belt.
During a temporary truce, both armies burn their dead on giant pyres, and the Achaeans build a monumental ditch and palisade to
protect their ships.
SCENE 19: NO-MAN'S-LAND — HECTOR'S CHALLENGE & CASTING OF LOTS — DAY
Hector stepped between the armies, holding his spear by the middle, and made the Trojan ranks sit down in
rows. Agamemnon did likewise with the Achaeans. Athena and Apollo sat upon a tall oak tree in the likeness of
vultures, delighting in the spectacle of the heroes bristling with shields and spears.
Hector stood tall between the hosts: "Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans! Let whoever among you boasts to be the
best champion step forward to duel with godlike Hector! If he slays me with his bronze, let him strip my armor and bear it to
the hollow ships, but let him give my body back to my home, that the Trojans and Trojan wives may give me my due share of
fire in death! And if I slay him and Apollo grants me glory, I will hang his armor in the temple of Apollo, but his body I will
send back to the ships, that the Achaeans may heap a mound over him by the wide Hellespont! And some sailor in days to
come will say: 'This is the tomb of a hero of old who was slain by glorious Hector!' So will men say, and my glory shall never
die!"
The Achaeans sat in stricken silence—ashamed to refuse, yet terrified to accept. Finally Nestor shamed the assembly, and
nine heroes leaped to their feet. Lots were scratched and tossed into Agamemnon's helmet. Nestor shook it, and out leaped
the lot of Great Ajax.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos

aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"
Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"
Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink
no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your
heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and
deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
bestow it!"
Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,

frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
tang of forged bronze.
Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes;
Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set
foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"
Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in
Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to
those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"
In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s
greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it
escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"
Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the
fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and
all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon whispered to Glaucus: "Glaucus, look at the wall of bronze before us. It is terrifying, yet it is glorious!
We are mortal men, born of mortal mothers, and our span of days is brief as a morning mist! Let us make our names an
immortal song for generations yet unborn!"
Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans!
Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"
The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting
tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.

Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound!
We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"

Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles' tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this
road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his
comrades, with which we honored him above all beside the ships! A man accepts blood-money even for his brother's murder
or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"
Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with
insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives
and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
fight!"
Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to
tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"
The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.
Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born,
but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory
is in our hands!"
A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 20: THE DUEL OF THE GIANTS — AJAX AND HECTOR — SUNSET
Telamonian Ajax strode forward like the god Ares going to war, carrying his seven-fold ox-hide shield overlaid
with an eighth layer of solid bronze. Smiling with grim countenance, shaking his massive spear, he faced Hector.
Ajax's voice boomed across the dust: "Hector, now you shall learn man-to-man what chieftains the Danaans have, even

without Achilles, breaker of men, who sits nursing his wrath by the beaked ships! Begin the battle!"
Hector cast his spear; it pierced six layers of tough ox-hide but stuck fast in the seventh. Ajax cast his spear clean through
Hector’s shield and corselet, grazing his neck. They drew their long bronze swords and closed like flesh-eating lions.
Hector stepped back and seized with his hand a black, jagged boulder lying upon the plain. He hurled it against Ajax’s
seven-fold shield, making the bronze ring like a struck anvil. But Ajax lifted an even larger millstone and hurled it with
cosmic force, smashing Hector’s shield inward and knocking the Trojan prince flat upon his back in the dust! Apollo instantly
raised him up.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
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Odysseus looked into Achilles' dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the

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and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
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Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to
tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"
The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born,
but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
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is in our hands!"
A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 21: THE NOBLE PARTING & THE SHADOW OF NIGHT — DUSK
As both heroes drew their swords to hack each other in close combat, the heralds Idaios and Talthybius held
their sacred staves between them, bidding them cease as night was falling.
Hector sheathed his blade: "Ajax, since god gave you size, strength, and wisdom, and you are the best spearman of the
Achaeans, let us cease our fighting for this day! But come, let us give each other glorious gifts, that both Trojans and
Achaeans may say: 'These two fought indeed in soul-devouring strife, but parted in friendship and concord!'"
Hector unbuckled his silver-studded sword with its scabbard and baldric, giving it to Ajax; and Ajax gave to Hector his
brilliant purple war-belt. They parted into the gathering darkness, each army rejoicing that their champion had survived.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"
Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The

way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
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bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"
Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink
no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
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At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and
deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
bestow it!"
Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
tang of forged bronze.

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arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 8: THE GOLDEN SCALES OF ZEUS & THE FIRES ON THE PLAIN

Zeus summons the gods at dawn, forbidding any immortal from intervening on pain of being cast into Tartarus. He mounts his chariot to Mount Ida and weighs the golden scales of fate: the Achaean destiny sinks to the earth. Zeus hurls thunderbolts onto the battlefield, throwing the Greeks into panic. Nestor is nearly killed before Diomedes rescues him. The Trojans drive the Greeks across their newly built ditch to the black ships. Hera attempts to incite Poseidon, but Zeus threatens her with his lightning. Night falls, saving the Achaeans from destruction. Hector bivouacs fifty thousand Trojan warriors on the open plain, lighting a thousand watchfires that blaze like constellations under the Trojan stars.

SCENE 22: THE SUMMIT OF IDA — THE GOLDEN SCALES OF ZEUS — MORNING

Zeus sat upon the peak of Mount Ida, overlooking Troy and the ships: "At midday, the Father suspended his golden scales in the sky, placing therein two fates of death that lays men low—one for the horse-taming Trojans, and one for the bronze-clad Achaeans. He held the balance by the middle: down sank the day of doom for the Achaeans, resting upon the bounteous earth, while the Trojan scale soared toward the wide heaven!"

[Deafening crack of cosmic thunder; a bolt of white lightning strikes directly before the chariot of Diomedes, filling the air with burning sulfur]

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
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your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
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the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
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The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
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arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 23: THE DITCH BEFORE THE SHIPS — THE TROJAN BREAKTHROUGH — AFTERNOON
Hector drove his snorting horses to the ditch, his eyes blazing like the Gorgon: "Trojans, Lycians, and
Dardanians! Be men, my friends, and remember furious courage! I know that Zeus has nodded his head to grant
me victory and glory, but to the Danaans ruin! Bring fire for their ships! Today we shall burn their hollow hulls
and slaughter the smoked-out Achaeans beside their own sterns!"
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives
and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
fight!"
Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to
tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"
The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.
Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born,
but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory
is in our hands!"
A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 24: THE TROJAN BIVOUAC — THE THOUSAND WATCHFIRES — NIGHT
As when in heaven the stars shine clear and luminous around the radiant moon when the wind is calm, and all
the mountain peaks, spurs, and vales appear, and the boundless sky breaks open, and the shepherd rejoices in his
heart: so countless between the ships and the streams of Xanthus blazed the watchfires of the Trojans. A

thousand fires burned in the plain, and beside each sat fifty warriors in the red glare of the burning embers,
while their horses munched white barley beside the chariots, waiting for the golden-throned Dawn.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"
Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink
no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your
heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and
deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
bestow it!"
Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
tang of forged bronze.
Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes;
Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set
foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"
Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in
Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to
those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"
In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s
greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it
escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"
Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the
fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and
all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon whispered to Glaucus: "Glaucus, look at the wall of bronze before us. It is terrifying, yet it is glorious!
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immortal song for generations yet unborn!"
Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans!

Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"
The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting
tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.
Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound!
We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"
Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles' tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this
road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his
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or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"
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A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the

man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 9: THE EMBASSY OF BRONZE & ACHILLES' REJECTION OF GLORY

Panic grips the Achaeans. Agamemnon weeps openly in the council of kings, proposing to abandon the war. Diomedes defies him,
declaring he will fight alone if needed. Nestor urges reconciliation with Achilles. Agamemnon publicly admits his madness and
offers immense reparations: seven bronze tripods, ten talents of gold, twenty gleaming caldrons, twelve prize racehorses, seven
captive women of Lesbos, the return of Briseis untouched by his bed, and after the war, one of his three daughters in marriage and
seven rich cities. An embassy consisting of Odysseus, aged tutor Phoenix, and Great Ajax visits Achilles' tent. Achilles welcomes
them hospitably, but delivers the most famous philosophical speech in world literature, utterly rejecting Agamemnon's gifts,
exposing the hollow illusion of glory bought with an early grave.

SCENE 25: THE ROYAL COUNCIL — AGAMEMNON'S REPENTANCE — NIGHT

Agamemnon stood before the assembled chieftains, tears pouring down his face like a dark spring dripping black
water down a sheer rock face.

Agamemnon choked on his words: "Friends, leaders and counselors of the Argives! Zeus has bound me in blind delusion! I
was mad; I do not deny it myself! Worth many armies is the man whom Zeus loves in his heart, even as he honors Achilles
now. But since I erred, yielding to miserable passions, I am willing to make amends and offer boundless ransom! Before you
all, I name the gifts: seven tripods, ten talents of gold, twenty caldrons, twelve prize racehorses, and seven women of Lesbos,
skilled in handiwork, whom I chose on the day he took Lesbos! And with them shall go the daughter of Briseus, and I will
swear a mighty oath that I never mounted her bed! All this at once; and if the gods grant us to sack Troy, let him heap his ship
with gold and bronze, and choose twenty Trojan women, and wed my daughter without bride-price! Only let him yield! Let
him submit to me, inasmuch as I am more royal and older than he!"

Nestor nodded his white head: "Most glorious son of Atreus, no man can find fault with the gifts you offer! Let chosen men
go immediately to the tent of Achilles: let Phoenix lead the way, and with him great Ajax and noble Odysseus!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient

knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"
Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
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towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
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Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink
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heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"
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Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
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frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
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immortal song for generations yet unborn!"
Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans!
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The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting
tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.
Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
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We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 26: THE TENT OF ACHILLES — THE WELCOME & ODYSSEUS' PLEA — NIGHT
The envoys walked along the shore of the sounding sea, praying to Poseidon the Earth-Shaker. They reached the
tents and ships of the Myrmidons, and found Achilles delighting his heart with a clear-toned silver lyre that he

had taken from the spoils of Thebe, singing the glorious deeds of heroes. Beside him sat Patroclus alone in
silence, waiting for the son of Peleus to cease his song.
Achilles sprang up in surprise, still holding the lyre in his hand: "Welcome! Truly you are friends who have come—men dear
to me above all the Achaeans, even in my wrath!" He led them within, set them upon purple chairs, and commanded
Patroclus to mingle stronger wine and roast the choice backs of sheep and fat goats.
Odysseus raised his golden cup, reciting Agamemnon’s boundless catalog of gifts, then leaned forward: "Achilles, our ships
are smoking in the sand! Hector boasts he will burn the fleet at dawn! If your hatred for Agamemnon is too deep, at least take
pity on the dying host of the Achaeans, who will honor you like a god! For now you might slay Hector, who in his raving
madness comes close to our ships, boasting that no Danaan is his equal!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 27: ACHILLES' MONUMENTAL REFUSAL — THE REJECTION OF GLORY — NIGHT
Achilles looked into Odysseus' eyes, his voice slicing like a diamond blade: "Resourceful Odysseus, son of
Laertes, I must speak my word bluntly, exactly as I think and as it shall be accomplished, so that you may not sit
before me cooing your persuasions! For hateful to me as the gates of Hades is that man who hides one thing in
his heart and speaks another! As for me, neither Agamemnon nor any Danaan shall persuade me, since there is
no gratitude for fighting incessantly against enemies without end! One fate awaits the man who stays behind and
him who fights with all his might; in equal honor are held the coward and the brave; death comes alike to the
man who does nothing and the man who accomplishes much! Like a bird that brings every scrap of food she can
find to her unfledged chicks while she herself goes hungry, so have I spent many sleepless nights and bloody days
in combat, winning cities only that Agamemnon might gorge himself upon the spoils! He took Briseis, my
beloved wife in my heart, while he keeps his own! Do the sons of Atreus alone of all mortal men love their wives?
Every noble and sensible man loves and cherishes his own woman, as I loved her from the bottom of my heart,
prize of my spear though she was! He deceived me and robbed me; let him not test me again, for he will not
persuade me! Let him look to you, Odysseus, and Ajax, to keep the devouring fire from his black ships! He built
a wall and dug a ditch—yet Hector cannot be stopped by his ditch! When I was in the field, Hector never dared

venture far from the Scaean gate! Tomorrow, Odysseus, if you care to watch, you will see my ships sailing across
the Hellespont, rowing home to Phthia! For my mother, silver-footed Thetis, tells me of two fates that carry me to
the end of death: if I stay here and fight around the city of the Trojans, my return home is lost, but my glory
shall be immortal; and if I return to my dear fatherland, my proud glory is lost, but a long life shall be mine, and
the doom of death will not overtake me swiftly! I counsel all of you to sail for home, for you will never see the fall
of steep Ilium; the hand of wide-throning Zeus shields her!"
Silence fell upon the tent. The ambassadors sat dumbfounded, stunned by the fierce finality of his refusal.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"
Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of

bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"
Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink
no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your
heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and
deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
bestow it!"
Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
tang of forged bronze.
Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes;
Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set
foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"
Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in
Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to
those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"
In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon's
greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it
escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"
Odysseus looked into Achilles' dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the
fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and

all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon whispered to Glaucus: "Glaucus, look at the wall of bronze before us. It is terrifying, yet it is glorious!
We are mortal men, born of mortal mothers, and our span of days is brief as a morning mist! Let us make our names an
immortal song for generations yet unborn!"
Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans!
Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"
The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting
tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.

Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound!
We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"
Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles' tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this
road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his
comrades, with which we honored him above all beside the ships! A man accepts blood-money even for his brother's murder
or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"
Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with
insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives
and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
fight!"
Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to
tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"
The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born,
but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory
is in our hands!"
A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 10: THE DOLONEIA — NIGHT RAID AND THE STEEDS OF RHESUS

Agamemnon and Menelaus cannot sleep for anxiety. They awaken the senior chieftains and hold a council at the trench. Nestor
suggests a nocturnal reconnaissance mission into the Trojan camp. Diomedes volunteers and selects Odysseus as his companion.
Simultaneously, Hector sends out the scout Dolon, promising him the chariot and horses of Achilles as reward. Diomedes and
Odysseus intercept Dolon in no-man's-land, extract complete intelligence about the Trojan dispositions and the newly arrived
Thracian allies under King Rhesus, and slay him. Infiltrating the sleeping Thracian camp, Diomedes butchers twelve warriors and
King Rhesus, while Odysseus untethers the divine white horses faster than the wind, returning triumphantly to the Achaean camp.
SCENE 28: NO-MAN'S-LAND — CAPTURE OF DOLON — MIDNIGHT
Clothed in a wolf-skin with a cap of ferret-skin, Dolon the Trojan sped through the dark toward the Achaean
ships. Odysseus heard his footfalls in the dry thistles and signaled Diomedes to lie low among the corpses until he
had passed, then sprang out behind him like two sharp-toothed hounds tracking a fawn.
Odysseus caught him by the shoulder: "Halt, Trojan, or my spear will overtake you! Speak: why do you prowl through the
black night toward our ships? Is it to strip the dead, or did Hector send you to spy upon our fleet?"
Dolon's knees knocked together: "Spare my life! Hector lured me into folly, promising to give me the bronze chariot and the
immortal horses of Peleus' son Achilles! Take me alive; my father has boundless copper, gold, and iron, and will pay an
immense ransom when he learns I am held at the ships!"
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"
Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The

way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
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your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
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deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
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The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
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The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
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tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.
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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
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The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 29: THE MIDNIGHT INTERROGATION & DOLON’S FATE — NIGHT
Odysseus extracted every secret: the placement of the Carians, Paeonians, and the newly arrived Thracians
encamped on the flank under King Rhesus, whose horses were whiter than snow and swift as the wind.
Diomedes scowled: "Do not imagine you can escape, Dolon, now that you have fallen into our hands! For if we ransom you
or let you go, you will come again tomorrow to spy on our ships or fight in battle; but if you lose your life under my hands,
you will never bring harm to the Argives again!"
As Dolon reached up with his hand to touch Diomedes’ chin in supplication, Diomedes struck him across the neck with his
heavy sword. The blade sliced through both sinews; and while he was still speaking, his severed head rolled in the dust.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 30: THE THRACIAN CAMP — SLAUGHTER OF RHESUS — PRE-DAWN
Like a lion falling upon an unguarded flock of sheep, Diomedes butchered twelve sleeping Thracian warriors,
their blood spurting over their silver armor. King Rhesus lay thirteenth, gasping his life out in a nightmare sent
by Athena. Odysseus untethered the marvelous white horses with his bow, leaped upon their backs, and rode
laughing back to the Achaean camp as the first grey light of dawn touched the sea.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"
Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"
Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink

no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your
heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and
deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
bestow it!"
Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
tang of forged bronze.
Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes;
Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set
foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"
Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in
Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to
those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"

In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s
greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it
escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"
Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the
fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and
all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon whispered to Glaucus: "Glaucus, look at the wall of bronze before us. It is terrifying, yet it is glorious!

We are mortal men, born of mortal mothers, and our span of days is brief as a morning mist! Let us make our names an
immortal song for generations yet unborn!"
Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans!
Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"
The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting
tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.
Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound!
We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"
Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles' tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this
road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his
comrades, with which we honored him above all beside the ships! A man accepts blood-money even for his brother's murder
or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"
Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with
insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives
and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
fight!"
Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to
tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"
The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.
Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born,
but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory
is in our hands!"

A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 11: THE WOUNDING OF THE CHIEFTAINS & PATROCLUS AT NESTOR'S

At dawn, Strife rages over the plain. Agamemnon leads a ferocious rampage, driving the Trojans to the city walls until he is
wounded by a spear in the arm. Hector counter-attacks. Diomedes is shot through the foot by Paris' arrow; Odysseus is surrounded
and wounded in the ribs by Soco; Eurypylus is wounded by an arrow. Achilles, watching the catastrophe from the high stern of his
black ship, sends Patroclus to Nestor's tent to discover which wounded hero was carried from the field. Nestor delivers an
impassioned plea to Patroclus, proposing that if Achilles will not fight, Patroclus should put on Achilles' armor to terrify the
Trojans.

SCENE 31: THE PLAIN OF TROY — THE CHIEFTAINS STRICKEN — DAY

Agamemnon's spear tore through the Trojan ranks until Coön pierced his forearm beneath the elbow. The
wound stiffened with agony, forcing the High King to retreat to his chariot. Seeing the king withdraw, Hector
shouted to his men and charged like a black whirlwind.

Paris drew his curved bow, shooting an arrow that pinned Diomedes' right foot clean through to the earth! Laughing in
mockery, Paris sprang from behind the grave-pillar of Ilus, while Diomedes tore the arrow out and withdrew. Then Odysseus
stood alone, surrounded by Trojans like a wild boar surrounded by hounds, fighting until Soco's spear slashed through his
ribs.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"
Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink
no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your
heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
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deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
bestow it!"
Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
tang of forged bronze.
Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes;
Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set

foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"
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Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to
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In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s
greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it
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Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the
fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and
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tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.
Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound!
We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"
Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles’ tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this
road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his
comrades, with which we honored him above all beside the ships! A man accepts blood-money even for his brother’s murder
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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with

insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
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and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
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them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.
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but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
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A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 32: THE STERN OF ACHILLES' SHIP — THE FATAL COMMAND — AFTERNOON
Achilles stood upon the high stern of his curved ship, looking out over the plain: "Beloved Patroclus, joy of my
heart! Now I think the Achaeans will stand around my knees in supplication, for an agony past enduring has
overtaken them! Go, Patroclus, beloved of Zeus, and ask Nestor what wounded man he has carried from the
fight!"
Patroclus said, "Patroclus ran along the tents, and this was the beginning of his doom."
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
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way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
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your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"
Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles' knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink
no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your
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At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
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bestow it!"
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The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,

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the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
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man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 33: NESTOR'S TENT — THE SEED OF THE PATROCLEIA — AFTERNOON
Nestor gripped Patroclus' arm: "Why does Achilles pity only some sons of the Achaeans, while the whole host is
perishing? The bravest chieftains lie wounded in their ships—Diomedes, Odysseus, Agamemnon, Eurypylus!
Will Achilles wait until our swift ships are burned with consuming fire? If Achilles holds back because of some

secret prophecy from his mother, let him at least send you into the fight, and give you his Myrmidons, and let you
put on his glorious armor! The Trojans will take you for him and shrink from battle, and the worn-out sons of
the Achaeans will have room to breathe!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods
themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your

heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How
shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and
deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or
bestow it!"
Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans
is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp
tang of forged bronze.
Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes;
Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set
foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"
Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in
Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to
those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"

In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s
greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it
escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"
Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the
fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and
all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon whispered to Glaucus: "Glaucus, look at the wall of bronze before us. It is terrifying, yet it is glorious!
We are mortal men, born of mortal mothers, and our span of days is brief as a morning mist! Let us make our names an
immortal song for generations yet unborn!"

Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans!
Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"
The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting
tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.
Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound!
We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
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Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles' tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this
road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his
comrades, with which we honored him above all beside the ships! A man accepts blood-money even for his brother's murder
or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"
Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with
insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives
and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
fight!"
Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to
tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"
The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.
Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born,
but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory
is in our hands!"
A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

BOOK 12: THE STORMING OF THE DIKE & HECTOR SHATTERS THE GATE

The Trojans divide into five battalions to storm the ditch and wall. An eagle flies on the left, holding a blood-red serpent that bites
the eagle’s breast; Polydamas urges Hector to retreat, but Hector rebukes him with the immortal line that the best omen is to fight
for one’s fatherland. Sarpedon delivers his famous philosophical speech to Glaucus on the moral justification of royal privilege
through courage. Sarpedon breaches the battlements with his bare hands. Hector lifts an enormous, jagged boulder—which two
men could not load onto a wagon—and hurls it clean through the high double oak doors of the Achaean wall, bursting through like
black night with fire in his eyes.

SCENE 34: THE DITCH — THE OMEN & HECTOR’S CREED — DAY

A high-flying eagle soared over the Trojan host, clutching in its talons a huge spotted serpent, alive and
struggling. The snake reared back and struck the eagle on the breast beside the neck. In agony the eagle dropped
the serpent into the midst of the crowd and flew screeching away on the wind.

Hector turned upon Polydamas with flashing eyes: "Polydamas, your words displease me! You bid me forget the solemn
counsel of thunder-throning Zeus and put my trust in birds that wing their way through the air! I care not whether they fly to
the right toward the dawn, or to the left toward the misty gloom! One omen is the best of all: to fight for our fatherland!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
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or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"

Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
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insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives
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is in our hands!"
A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.
SCENE 35: THE BATTLEMENTS — SARPEDON’S IMMORTAL SPEECH — AFTERNOON
Sarpedon turned to Glaucus: "Glaucus, why are we two honored above all with the front seat at feasts, choice
meats, and brimming cups in Lycia, and all men gaze upon us like gods, and we possess a vast estate of orchards
and wheat-bearing fields? For this reason it is our duty now to stand in the front rank of the Lycians and face the
blazing fight, that some armored warrior may say: 'Not without glory do our kings rule Lycia, eating fat sheep
and drinking honey-sweet wine; for their strength is excellent, and they fight in the front lines!' Ah, friend, if
escaping from this war would grant us to live forever, ageless and immortal, I would neither fight myself in the
front rank nor urge you on into battle! But now, since ten thousand shapes of death stand over us, which no
mortal man can escape or avoid: let us go forward, whether we shall grant glory to another, or another to us!"
With a mighty shout, Sarpedon leaped upon the parapet, gripped the breastwork with his bare hands, and tore it away. A wide

breach opened in the wall.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their
swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing
this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The
way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the
towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"
Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the
parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble
your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can
hold back the torch of Hector!"
In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in
the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to
those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of
bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that
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arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 36: THE HIGH GATE — HECTOR SHATTERS THE TIMBER DOORS — DUSK

Hector stepped before the towering double doors of the central gate, reinforced with crossbars and two heavy
iron bolts. Beside the gate lay a colossal boulder, pointed at the top, broad at the base, which two of the strongest
men among our generation could not pry up with crowbars onto a wagon. Hector lifted it effortlessly, as a
shepherd carries the fleece of a ram in one hand.

Setting his feet wide, putting the weight of his whole body into the cast, Hector hurled the boulder with terrible force against
the middle of the doors. The hinges tore away, the bolts snapped with a crack like thunder, and the heavy timbers shattered
inward under the impact! In leaped glorious Hector, his face like sudden night, his bronze armor blazing with unearthly fire,
two spears held in his fists! The Trojans poured through the gate and over the walls, and the panicked Achaeans fled among
their hollow ships in unceasing uproar.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"
Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in
Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to
those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"

In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon's
greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it
escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"
Odysseus looked into Achilles' dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the
fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and
all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"
At the ditch, Sarpedon whispered to Glaucus: "Glaucus, look at the wall of bronze before us. It is terrifying, yet it is glorious!
We are mortal men, born of mortal mothers, and our span of days is brief as a morning mist! Let us make our names an
immortal song for generations yet unborn!"
Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans!
Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"
The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting
tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.
Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to
one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound!
We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is
not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"
Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles' tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this
road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his
comrades, with which we honored him above all beside the ships! A man accepts blood-money even for his brother's murder
or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"
Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say
almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with
insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of
bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives
and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for
fight!"

Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to
tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"
The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered
them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born,
but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"
Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory
is in our hands!"
A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand
mingled under the darkening heavens.
The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the
man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"
The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and
arrows along the sounding shore.

ACT 3: THE BREACH OF THE WALL & THE DEATH OF PATROCLUS

The Blazing Ships, Sacrificial Friendship & Mortal Destiny

BOOK 13: THE BATTLE AT THE BLACK SHIPS & POSEIDON'S RALLY

Zeus turns his eyes away from Troy, believing no god will dare disobey his decree. Poseidon seizes the opportunity: emerging from
his undersea palace of Aegae in his golden sea-chariot, he enters the Achaean lines disguised as the seer Calchas, breathing heroic
fury into the two Ajaxes and rallying the terrified Danaans. King Idomeneus of Crete leads a valiant counter-attack in the center.
Hand-to-hand carnage erupts around the black hulls, where bronze spears clash against shields and men fall like felled pines upon
the sand.
SCENE 37: THE COAST OF SAMOTHRACE & THE GREEK SHIPS — DAY
From the highest wooded peak of Samothrace, Poseidon watched the slaughter with a heavy heart. He strode
down the mountain slopes, and the tall peaks and forests trembled beneath the immortal feet of the god. Yoking
his bronze-hoofed sea-steeds with golden manes, he skimmed across the waves, while sea-monsters gamboled
around his chariot from the abyss.
Poseidon struck the ground with his trident: "Ajaxes! You two must save the Achaean host, remembering valor and not
chilling panic! On the plain elsewhere I do not fear the Trojan hands, but here I dread disaster, where Hector like a devouring
fire leads the way, boasting to be the son of almighty Zeus! Let some god put it into your breasts to stand firm yourselves and
rally the rest!"
He touched them both with his staff, filling their limbs with tireless might, making their hands and feet light as birds. The two
Ajaxes recognized the departing stride of a god, their hearts leaping with martial joy.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let

the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"
In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is
Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and
let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"
Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
into a dark twilight of ash and embers.

Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons!
Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send
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unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.
Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus' belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save
you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"
Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo
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Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing
from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"
Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your
heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"
In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.
Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my
friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"

Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from

our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your
burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"
Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I
will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"
The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the
divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 38: THE LEFT WING — IDOMENEUS' ARISTEIA — AFTERNOON
Idomeneus charged into the fight like a blazing bolt of lightning, his grey hair flying under his bronze helmet. He
struck Asius through the throat just as the warrior stepped from his chariot; he speared Alcathous through the
heart, making the fallen warrior's shield ring with his dying heartbeats.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
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the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 39: THE STERN OF THE CENTRAL SHIPS — BRONZE LOCKS WITH BRONZE — DUSK
Shield pressed against shield, helmet against helmet, man against man. The horsehair crests touched on their
gleaming ridges as the warriors nodded their heads, so close they stood to one another. The flight of spears
bristled like a reaper's field of wheat, and the glitter of bronze blinded the eyes.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
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him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"
Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I
will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"
The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the
divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 14: THE BEGUILING OF ZEUS & THE SLUMBER ON MOUNT IDA

Seeing the Greek ships in mortal peril, Queen Hera conceives an audacious plan to beguile Zeus. She bathes in ambrosia, dresses in
celestial robes, and tricks Aphrodite into lending her the magical embroidered girdle containing love, desire, and seductive sweet
talk that steals the wits of the wisest men. She enlists Hypnos, the god of sleep, promising him the hand of the Grace Pasithea.
Ascending Mount Ida, Hera seduces Zeus; seized by overwhelming passion, Zeus envelops them in a golden cloud while the earth
puts forth blooming hyacinths and crocuses. As Zeus falls into profound sleep, Hypnos signals Poseidon, who leads an all-out
counter-offensive. Telamonian Ajax hurls an enormous stone that strikes Hector full in the chest, knocking him unconscious and
forcing the Trojans to retreat.
SCENE 40: THE SUMMIT OF IDA — THE BEGUILING OF ZEUS — NOON
Wearing the magic girdle of Aphrodite, fragrant with celestial perfume, Hera ascended to the peak of Mount Ida
where Zeus sat. The moment Zeus looked upon her, desire seized his heart like the first day they had joined in
love in secret from their parents.
Zeus caught her hand: "Hera, never has love for any goddess or mortal woman so overwhelmed the heart within my breast as
this desire for you now! Come, let us take our delight in bed!"
The son of Cronus clasped his wife in his arms. Beneath them the divine earth blossomed with fresh green grass, dewy
lotuses, crocuses, and soft hyacinths, lifting them high from the ground. A thick golden cloud enveloped them, and sweet
sleep sealed the eyelids of the Father of gods and men.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let

the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"
Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is
Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and
let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"
Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
into a dark twilight of ash and embers.

Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons!
Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send
my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return
unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.
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Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo
and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"
Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing
from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"
Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your
heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"
In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.
Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my
friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"
Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"

Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your burning pyre!"

All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 41: THE BATTLE AT THE WALL — AJAX STRIKES HECTOR — AFTERNOON

Poseidon leaped to the front, brandishing a long flashing sword like a thunderbolt. Hector cast his spear at Ajax, but it struck where the two baldrics crossed and fell harmlessly. As Hector stepped back to the safety of his comrades, Telamonian Ajax seized one of the enormous boulders that served as props for the black ships.

Whirling the stone like a spinning top, Ajax struck Hector full in the chest over the rim of his shield! Hector spun like an uprooted oak tree felled by a lightning bolt of Zeus, and collapsed vomiting dark blood, his spear and shield crashing over him. His comrades dragged his limp body back to the river Xanthus, pouring cool water over his pale face.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above

the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
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brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let
the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"
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Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"
In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is
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Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your

own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
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into a dark twilight of ash and embers.
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Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
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Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
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We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
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Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
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shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 42: THE RETREAT OF THE TROJANS — DUSK
Seeing Hector carried senseless from the field, panic seized the Trojans. The Danaans surged forward with

spears and swords, driving the horse-taming Trojans back across the ditch in bloody rout. The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
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Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
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own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
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BOOK 15: ZEUS AWAKES & THE FLAMING TORCHES AT THE HULLS

Zeus awakens upon Mount Ida to see Hector vomiting blood and the Trojans in full flight. Furious at Hera's trickery, he threatens
her with whipping and chains, recalling how he once suspended her from heaven with golden anvils on her feet. Zeus lays down the
grand divine plan: Poseidon must withdraw; Apollo will revive Hector and grant him irresistible strength; the Trojans will burn the
ships until Patroclus enters the battle and slays Sarpedon, only to be slain by Hector; and finally, Achilles will rise in fury and slay
Hector, sealing the doom of Troy. Apollo breathes unearthly vigor into Hector and leads the Trojans with the terrifying Aegis. The
Trojans reach the beached ships. Hector orders torches thrown into the hulls. Great Ajax leaps from deck to deck, defending the
ship of Protesilaus with a 22-cubit naval boarding pike, slaying twelve Trojans in single combat as the first flames erupt.

SCENE 43: MOUNT IDA — ZEUS' AWAKENING & THE MASTER PLAN — DAY

Zeus sprang up, glaring at Hera with terrible eyes: "Miserable, deceitful Hera! Your treacherous cunning has
driven Hector from the fight and routed his people! Remember how I hung you from heaven with two golden
anvils tied to your feet and unbreakable golden chains about your wrists, while all the gods on Olympus looked
on in helpless terror? Send Iris to bid Poseidon cease from war, and send Apollo to breathe new strength into
Hector! Hector shall drive the Achaeans back upon the ships of Achilles! Then Achilles shall send forth his
comrade Patroclus, whom Hector shall slay with his spear before Ilium, after Patroclus has slain my own son,
noble Sarpedon! And enraged for Patroclus, godlike Achilles shall slay Hector! From that hour onward, I will
cause the tide of war to turn ceaselessly from the ships until the Achaeans take steep Ilium by the counsel of
Athena! Until that hour, my wrath will not cease!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our

brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let
the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
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Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is
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let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"
Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
into a dark twilight of ash and embers.
Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons!
Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send
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Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus' belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save
you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"
Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo
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Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing
from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"
Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your
heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"
In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.
Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my
friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"
Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from

our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"

Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow:
"Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your
burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"
Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I
will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"
The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the
divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 44: THE RIVER SCAMANDER — APOLLO REVIVES HECTOR — AFTERNOON
Apollo stood over the gasping prince: "Hector, son of Priam! Why sit you faint and heart-broken apart from
your comrades? I am Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword, sent by the son of Cronus to stand by your side! Up!
Command your horsemen to drive their swift chariots toward the hollow ships! I will march before you, leveling
the road and turning the Achaean heroes to flight!"
As a stalled horse that has broken his halter gallops across the plain to bathe in the fair-flowing river, tossing his head high
while his mane streams over his shoulders, so Hector moved his swift limbs, rushing to lead his men.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
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bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let
the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
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Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"
In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
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let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
into a dark twilight of ash and embers.
Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons!
Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
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you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"
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from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"
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In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.

Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my

friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
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Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"
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We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your
burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
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The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 45: THE FIRST SHIP — AJAX AND THE 22-CUBIT PIKE — DUSK

Apollo kicked down the earthen rampart of the Achaeans as easily as a child kicks down a sandcastle he built on
the seashore. The Trojans swarmed over the ships. Hector seized the high stern of the ship of Protesilaus,
shouting for fire.
Hector gripped the carved prow: "Bring fire! Raise the war-shout all together! Zeus has given us a day worth all our toil: to
capture the ships that sailed here against the will of the gods!"
Great Ajax could hold his ground no longer under the storm of arrows, but retreated to the seven-foot helmsman’s bench. In
his hands he wielded a colossal naval boarding pike, twenty-two cubits long, bound with bronze rings. Whenever any Trojan
rushed forward with a blazing brand to set fire to the black wood, Ajax impaled him with his long pike, slaying twelve
warriors in front of the hull.

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the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 16: THE PATROCLEIA — THE ARMOR OF ACHILLES & SLAYING OF SARPEDON

Patroclus runs weeping to Achilles, begging for permission to lead the Myrmidons in Achilles' armor. Seeing black smoke rise from
the burning ship of Protesilaus, Achilles agrees, ordering Patroclus strictly to drive the Trojans from the ships but not to assault the
walls of Troy. Patroclus puts on the divine armor of Achilles—except the Pelian ash spear, which Achilles alone can wield. The
Myrmidons charge like hungry wolves. Believing Achilles has returned, the Trojans break into panic. Patroclus extinguishes the fire
and slays King Sarpedon of Lycia in a titanic duel. Zeus weeps tears of blood for his fallen son. Swept by bloodlust, Patroclus
disobeys Achilles' warning and assaults the walls of Troy four times. Apollo strikes Patroclus from behind, stripping his helmet and
armor. Euphorbus spears him in the back, and Hector drives a bronze spear into his lower belly. In his dying words, Patroclus
prophesies Hector's imminent death at the hands of Achilles.

SCENE 46: THE TENT OF ACHILLES — PATROCLUS WEARING THE ARMOR — DAY

Achilles looked upon Patroclus with pity: "Why do you weep, Patroclus, like a little girl who runs beside her
mother, catching her dress and begging to be picked up? Have you bad news from Phthia? Peleus still lives, and
Menoetius; or do you grieve for the Argives who are perishing for their own arrogance?"

Patroclus groaned: "Achilles, strongest of the Achaeans! Do not be angry! All our bravest lie wounded in their ships! Your
father was not noble Peleus, nor was Thetis your mother; the grey sea bore you and the steep rocks, so cold and cruel is your
heart! If you will not fight, let me lead the Myrmidons! Clothe me in your own armor, that the Trojans may mistake me for
you and cease from slaughter!"

Across the bay, a column of black smoke and red flame shot into the sky: the ship of Protesilaus was burning! Achilles struck
his thighs with his hands.

Achilles shouted: "Up, Patroclus! I see the blazing fire roaring at the ships! Put on my armor, and I will marshal the
Myrmidons! But listen to my command: drive the Trojans from the ships and quench the flame, but do not pursue them
across the plain to steep Ilium! Do not fight against glorious Hector without me, lest some god from Olympus strike you
down! Return when the ships are saved!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the

Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"
In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
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Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and
let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"
Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until

dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
into a dark twilight of ash and embers.
Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons!
Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send
my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return
unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.
Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus' belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save
you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"
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and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"
Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing
from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"
Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your
heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"
In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.
Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my
friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us

for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"

Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your
burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"
Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I
will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"
The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the
divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 47: THE PLAIN OF SCAMANDER — THE FALL OF SARPEDON — AFTERNOON
Believing that Achilles had renounced his wrath, the Trojans panicked and fled the burning ships. Patroclus
drove his chariot through their ranks, slaughtering captains left and right. Then King Sarpedon of Lycia leaped
down to meet him.

High on Olympus, Zeus looked down with tears: "Ah me, that Sarpedon, dearest of men to me, is fated to be subdued by
Patroclus! My heart is divided: shall I snatch him alive from the tearful war and set him in rich Lycia, or let him fall beneath
the spear of Menoetius' son?" But Hera warned him that all gods would demand to save their mortal sons, and Zeus wept
bloody tears onto the earth.
They hurled their spears. Sarpedon missed, slaying the trace-horse Pedasus. But Patroclus' spear struck true, piercing the
diaphragm that encloses the beating heart. Sarpedon fell as an oak tree falls upon a mountain, felled by the axes of
woodsmen. Dying, he called to Glaucus to defend his armor and body.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let
the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"
In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
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Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and
let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"
Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
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Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send
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and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing

from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"
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heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"
In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.
Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my
friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"
Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your
burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"
Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I
will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"

The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the
divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 48: THE WALLS OF TROY — THE DEATH OF PATROCLUS — DUSK
Blind with victory, Patroclus forgot Achilles' strict command. Three times he assaulted the angle of the high wall
of Troy, and three times Apollo struck his flashing shield with immortal hands, shouting: "Withdraw, noble
Patroclus! It is not fated that the spear of your hand should take the proud city of the Trojans!"

Apollo came behind him in the thick of combat, shrouded in dense mist, and struck Patroclus between the shoulders with the
flat of his hand. His eyes spun in his head; the horsehair helmet was knocked from his curls and rolled ringing beneath the
horses' hooves; his great bronze-tipped spear shattered in his hands, and his shield fell to the earth. Stricken with blindness
and paralysis, Patroclus stood defenseless.
Euphorbus speared him in the back between the shoulder blades. As Patroclus staggered backward, Hector charged through
the front ranks and drove his heavy bronze spear clean through his lower belly, the point coming out his back.
Hector stood over him: "Patroclus! You thought you would sack our city, strip the day of freedom from our Trojan women,
and carry them home in ships! Fool! Before them the swift horses of Hector strain into battle! Vultures shall eat you here,
unhappy man! Nor did Achilles help you, though he gave you strict commands as you set forth!"
Patroclus whispered with his dying breath: "Boast while you can, Hector! Zeus and Apollo gave you this victory; they
stripped the armor from my shoulders, for twenty warriors like you could not have felled me! But mark well my words and
lay them in your heart: you yourself shall not live long! Already death and ruthless destiny stand close beside you, to be
subdued beneath the hands of Peleus' blameless son Achilles!" With those words, his soul flew from his limbs and went
down to the house of Hades, mourning its fate and leaving youth and manhood behind.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above

the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
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the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
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Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
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BOOK 17: THE STRUGGLE FOR THE BODY OF PATROCLUS & MENELAUS' STAND

A desperate, savage struggle erupts over the corpse of Patroclus. Menelaus slays Euphorbus. Hector strips the divine armor of
Achilles from Patroclus' body and straps it upon his own chest; Zeus looks down and pities Hector, knowing that Andromache will
never receive that armor back from battle. Great Ajax and Menelaus form an unbreakable wall over the stripped body. The
immortal horses of Achilles—Balius and Xanthus—stand motionless in the dust, weeping tears of grief for their gentle charioteer.
Zeus breathes strength into them. Wrapped in supernatural mist, Ajax prays to Zeus for light. Antilochus is dispatched to run to
Achilles with the tragic news, while Menelaus and Meriones carry the mangled corpse toward the ships under a storm of Trojan
spears.

SCENE 49: OVER THE BODY OF PATROCLUS — HECTOR DONS THE ARMOR — DAY

Hector dragged the corpse of Patroclus, intending to cut off his head and feed his flesh to the dogs of Troy. But
Great Ajax stepped forward with his wall-like shield, covering the body as a lioness protects her cubs. Hector
retreated, stripping the immortal armor of Achilles from Patroclus' shoulders.
Apart from the fight, Hector took off his own bronze armor and put on the immortal armor of Peleus' son Achilles. Zeus saw
him from Olympus and shook his head with sorrow.
Zeus whispered to his heart: "Ah, unhappy man! No thought of death is in your mind, yet death stands very close to you! You
put on the immortal armor of a peerless warrior, before whom all others tremble! His comrade you have slain, gentle and
strong, and stripped the armor unworthily from his head and shoulders! But now I will grant you immense glory, to atone for
this: that you shall never return from battle for Andromache to receive from your hands the glorious armor of Peleus' son!"
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
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Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
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Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
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Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send
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Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your
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In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
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Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my
friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"
Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"

Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your burning pyre!"

All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"

Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"

The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the divine armor was forged upon Olympus.

The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 50: THE REAR RANKS — THE TEARS OF THE IMMORTAL STEEDS — AFTERNOON

Apart from the battle, the immortal horses of Achilles stood weeping since they first learned that their gentle charioteer had fallen in the dust beneath the hands of man-slaying Hector. Automedon urged them with whip and soft words, but they would neither run back to the ships nor into the fight; but motionless as a grave-stele standing upon a mound, they stood with heads bowed to the earth, warm tears dropping from their eyelids as they mourned their driver, their flowing manes trailing in the dust.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the

Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let
the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"
Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"
In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
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Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
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All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
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crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 51: THE MIST-COVERED BATTLEFIELD — AJAX'S PRAYER — DUSK
Ajax looked through the blinding dark mist that covered the battle: "Father Zeus, deliver the sons of the
Achaeans from this dark mist! Clear the sky, let us see with our eyes, and destroy us in the light, since it is your

will to slay us!" Zeus pitied his tears and scattered the darkness. Menelaus dispatched swift-footed Antilochus to
carry the terrible news to Achilles.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
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Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
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the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 18: THE GRIEF OF ACHILLES & THE FORGING OF THE SHIELD OF HEPHAESTUS

Antilochus brings the news of Patroclus' death to Achilles. Achilles collapses in volcanic grief, pouring black ashes over his head
and tearing his hair with both hands. His groans echo across the sea; Thetis and the Nereids rise from the ocean abyss to weep with
him. Achilles vows to slay Hector, choosing a short life of immortal vengeance over long obscurity. Iris commands Achilles to show
himself at the trench; without armor, with a golden halo of divine fire kindled on his head by Athena, Achilles roars three times
across the ditch. The terrifying roar panics the Trojans, causing twelve heroes to be trampled by their own chariots, allowing the
Greeks to bear Patroclus' corpse safely to the camp. Thetis visits Hephaestus in his bronze palace; the divine smith forges for
Achilles new celestial armor, including the monumental Shield of Achilles depicting the cosmos, the city of peace, the city of war, the
plowing of fields, the vintage, the cattle, and the great River Oceanus encircling all existence.

SCENE 52: ACHILLES' HEADQUARTERS — THE AGONY OF PELEUS' SON — DUSK

Antilochus fell at Achilles' knees: "Ah me, son of wise Peleus! A bitter message must you hear! Fallen is
Patroclus! They are fighting over his naked body, and Hector of the gleaming helmet holds his armor!"

A black cloud of sorrow enveloped Achilles. He took dark soot from the hearth with both hands and poured it over his head,
defiling his handsome face; black ashes settled on his fragrant tunic. He threw his colossal frame upon the floor, tearing his
hair with both hands, groaning with a terrible roar that shook the earth.

Thetis heard him in the depths of the sea. She rose with all her sister Nereids, clasping her son's head: "Why do you weep,
my child? Zeus has accomplished all your prayers—the Achaeans are cooped up against their ships!"

Achilles cried aloud: "Mother, what joy have I of that, now that Patroclus is dead? Patroclus, whom I loved beyond all my
comrades, equal to my own life! I have destroyed him! May strife perish from among gods and men, and anger that makes a
man rave, sweeter than dripping honey in his breast! I will go now and find the destroyer of that beloved head—Hector! Then
let my doom fall when Zeus and the immortal gods decree it!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
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Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your
heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"
In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the
sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.
Patroclus leaped into Achilles' chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus' son Achilles! Be men, my
friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the
Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"

Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your
burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"
Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I
will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"
The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the
divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 53: THE DITCH BEFORE THE SHIPS — THE ROAR OF FLAME — SUNSET
Achilles strode to the ditch outside the wall, without armor. Athena crowned his head with a golden cloud from
which burst a blazing pillar of fire into the heavens, like a beacon lit on an island under siege.
[A roar like a bronze trumpet sounding when a city is besieged; Achilles shouts three times over the trench, and Athena roars
with him]

Three times godlike Achilles shouted over the ditch, and three times the Trojans and their allies broke in blind terror! Twelve of
their best champions died then and there, crushed upon their own spears and trampled by their own chariots. The Achaeans pulled
the body of Patroclus from the dust, laying him upon a bier, and Achilles walked beside his friend, weeping burning tears.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let
the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!
Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck;
death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"
Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear
Patroclus’ head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with
our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that
shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is
Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and
let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"
Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
into a dark twilight of ash and embers.
Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons!
Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus’ son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send
my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return
unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.
Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus’ belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save
you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"
Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo
and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"
Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing
from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus’ blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"
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Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
to the best of all the Achaeans!"
Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us
for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"
Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember
furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men?
We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from
our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your
burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
him a white shroud of pure wool.
Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in
his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"
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divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms

crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 54: THE FORGE OF HEPHAESTUS — THE COSMIC SHIELD — NIGHT
In his bronze house on Olympus, crippled Hephaestus set twenty bellows blowing into the crucibles, melting
tough bronze, tin, precious gold, and silver. With his heavy hammer in his right hand and tongs in his left, he
forged the colossal, five-layered Shield of Achilles.

Homeric Rhapsode (Narrator) said, "Upon it he fashioned the earth, the sky, the sea, the unwearied sun, the full moon, and all
the constellations that crown the heavens—the Pleiades, the Hyades, and the Great Bear. And upon it he made two cities of
mortal men: one of peace, with weddings, dancing, and elders giving righteous judgment in the marketplace; and one of war,
besieged by armies, ambushes by the river, and Strife dragging the wounded through the blood. He fashioned deep plowing
fields, a king’s estate where reapers bound the golden sheaves, a vineyard heavy with purple grapes, herds of cattle attacked
by lions, a dancing floor where youths and maidens danced hand-in-hand, and around the outermost rim he laid the mighty
stream of the River Oceanus encircling all mortal life."
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our
brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is
bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let
the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"
Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and
roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back!

Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds!
Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"
Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in
chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you
out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"
Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only
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Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and
let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"
Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your
own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until
dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky
into a dark twilight of ash and embers.

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Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus' son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to
snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"
Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send

my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return
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you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"
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Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor
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our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"
Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In
life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But
Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury
you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your

burning pyre!"
All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body
with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over
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divine armor was forged upon Olympus.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.

ACT 4: THE COSMIC SHIELD, THE FALL OF HECTOR & THE RANSOM

Vengeance, Theomachy, Shared Mortality & The Tears of Kings

BOOK 19: THE RENUNCIATION OF WRATH & THE ARMING OF THE ARISTOS

At dawn, Thetis lays the dazzling armor of Hephaestus at Achilles' feet. The armor clangs with celestial fire; the Myrmidons
tremble, but Achilles' eyes blaze with terrible joy. Achilles summons the assembly and renounces his wrath against Agamemnon.
Agamemnon admits his blindness, blaming Ate (Delusion), and delivers the immense reparations. Briseis weeps over the body of
Patroclus, recalling his gentle kindness. Achilles refuses food and drink, consumed solely by the hunger for battle; Athena invisibly
infuses nectar and ambrosia into his chest. Achilles straps on the divine armor, lifts the Pelian ash spear, and mounts his chariot.
His immortal horse Xanthus, granted human speech by Hera, prophesies Achilles' imminent death in battle; Achilles answers with
grim defiance that he knows his doom, and charges into the plain with a terrifying roar.
SCENE 55: THE TENT OF ACHILLES — THE HEAVENLY ARMOR — DAWN
Saffron-robed Dawn rose from the streams of Oceanus to bring light to mortals. Thetis reached the ships bearing
the glorious gifts of the god Hephaestus. She found her dear son weeping over Patroclus. The goddess set the
divine armor down before Achilles, and the intricate bronze clanged so loudly that all the Myrmidons shrank
back in terror, unable to gaze upon the blinding glare. But when Achilles looked upon the work of the god, his
wrath burned hotter within him; his eyes flashed beneath his lids like a blaze of fire.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"
Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between
wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your
flesh!"
In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has
ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!
Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.
Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of
all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with
sheets of flame.
Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter
the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
than live to see Troy in ashes!"
Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that
his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"
In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no
mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless
ransom!"
Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in
sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"
Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,
wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"
King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"

Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will

die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles' knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
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shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 56: THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY — RECONCILIATION & BRISEIS' TEARS — MORNING
Achilles stood before the wounded kings: "Son of Atreus! Was this better for the two of us, for you and for me,
when with broken hearts we raged in soul-devouring strife for the sake of a girl? Would that Artemis had slain
her with an arrow at the ships on the day I took her from Lyrnessus! Then so many Achaeans would not have
bitten the boundless earth beneath the hands of enemies while I nursed my anger! But what is done is done; let us

subdue the grief in our hearts! I here end my wrath; it does not become me to be relentlessly angry forever! Up,
lead the long-haired Achaeans into battle at once!"
Fair-cheeked Briseis returned to the tent. Seeing Patroclus mangled with bronze wounds, she threw herself upon the corpse,
tearing her breasts, soft throat, and lovely face.
Briseis wept: "Patroclus, dearest to my unhappy heart! Living I left you when I went from this tent, and now returning I find
you dead, leader of the people! Always sorrow upon sorrow pursues me! My husband was slain before our city, and my three
brothers whom one mother bore with me; but you would not even let me weep! You told me you would make me the wedded
wife of godlike Achilles, lead me in ships to Phthia, and celebrate our wedding among the Myrmidons! Therefore I weep for
you unceasingly in your death, for you were always gentle!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"
Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"
Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between
wolves and sheep! For Patroclus’ blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your
flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has
ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"
Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!
Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.
Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of
all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"
Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with
sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter
the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
than live to see Troy in ashes!"
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Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
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sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"
Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,
wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"
King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
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Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
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shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 57: THE CHARIOT OF ACHILLES — THE PROPHECY OF XANTHUS — NOON
Achilles armed himself. In his hands he lifted the Pelian ash spear, heavy, huge, and strong, which no other
Achaean could wield, cut from the peak of Pelion by Chiron for his father Peleus. He mounted his chariot with
Automedon.
From beneath the yoke, the swift horse Xanthus bowed his head until his golden mane touched the earth, and white-armed
Hera gave him human speech: "Truly we will save you this day, mighty Achilles! Yet the day of your doom is close at hand,
nor are we to blame, but a great god and ruthless Destiny! It was not by our slowness or laziness that the Trojans stripped the
armor from Patroclus' shoulders; the greatest of gods, son of lovely-haired Leto, slew him in the front ranks and gave the
glory to Hector! As for us two, we can run with the blast of the West Wind, swiftest of breezes; but for you it is fated to be
subdued by force beneath a god and a mortal man!"
Achilles shouted in wrath: "Xanthus, why prophesy my death? You need not! Well do I know myself that it is my fate to
perish here, far from my dear father and mother! Yet even so I will not cease until I have given the Trojans their fill of war!"
With a terrifying war-shout, he drove his horses into the front rank.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
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of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
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BOOK 20: THE BATTLE OF THE GODS (THEOMACHY) & ACHILLES ENTERS THE BATTLE

Fearing that Achilles in his demonic fury will storm Troy contrary to fate, Zeus lifts the ban on divine intervention, summoning all
gods to take whichever side they please. The heavens shake as the gods march to war: Hera, Athena, Poseidon, Hermes, and
Hephaestus join the Greeks; Ares, Apollo, Artemis, Leto, Scamander, and Aphrodite champion Troy. Thunder roars above from
Zeus; beneath, Poseidon shakes the boundless earth and mountain roots so violently that Hades springs from his throne in terror,
dreading that the roof of the underworld will crack open. Achilles sweeps across the plain like a forest fire on a drought-parched
mountain, his bronze chariot wheels and axle dripping with the blood and brains of slaughtered Trojans.

SCENE 58: MOUNT OLYMPUS — ZEUS LIFTS THE BAN — DAY

Zeus sat upon Olympus: "Go forth, all you immortals! Descend among the Trojans and Achaeans, and give aid
to whichever side your heart inclines! For if Achilles fights against the Trojans alone, they will not hold back the
swift son of Peleus for a moment! Even before, they trembled when they saw him; and now that he rages terribly
for his comrade, I fear he may breach the wall contrary to destiny!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
its immortal close.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 59: THE SHAKING OF THE THREE WORLDS — THEOMACHY — AFTERNOON
Terribly thundered the Father of gods and men from on high; beneath, Poseidon shook the boundless earth and
the steep mountain peaks. The spurs and summits of many-fountained Ida trembled, and the city of Troy, and
the ships of the Achaeans. Down in the underworld, Hades, king of the dead, leaped from his throne screaming in
terror, lest Poseidon tear the earth asunder and lay bare to mortals and immortals his moldering, dread halls
that the very gods abhor! So mighty was the crash when the gods collided in battle.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the

Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"
Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between
wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your
flesh!"
In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has
ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"
Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!
Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you

have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.
Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of
all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"
Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with
sheets of flame.
Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter
the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
than live to see Troy in ashes!"
Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that
his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"
In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no
mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless
ransom!"
Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in
sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"

Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,

wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus' son sweeps the field!"
King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles' knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
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The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
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Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
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Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
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The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms

crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 60: THE PLAIN OF TROY — ACHILLES' RAMPAGE — AFTERNOON

As a ravening wildfire rages through deep mountain glens on a parched hill, and the dense forest burns, and the
driving wind whirls the flame in every direction, so Achilles raged with his spear like a demon, pursuing those he
slew; and the dark earth ran with blood. As when a farmer yokes broad-browed bulls to trample white barley
upon a threshing-floor, and the grain is swiftly husked beneath the feet of the bellowing oxen, so under
great-hearted Achilles his solid-hoofed horses trampled corpses and shields together; the axle beneath was
drenched with blood, and the rims around the chariot-box were spattered with gory droplets from the hooves
and the wheels.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"
Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between
wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your
flesh!"
In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has
ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"
Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!
Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of
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Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with
sheets of flame.
Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter

the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
than live to see Troy in ashes!"
Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that
his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"
In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no
mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless
ransom!"
Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in
sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"
Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,
wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"
King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the

enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

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the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
its immortal close.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
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shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 21: ACHILLES BATTLES THE RIVER SCAMANDER & THE CONFLAGRATION

Achilles drives half the fleeing Trojans into the swirling waters of the River Scamander (Xanthus). He leaps into the river with his
sword, slaughtering warriors until the crystal waters run red with blood and corpses choke the stream. He captures twelve young
Trojan noblemen alive, binding their hands behind them with their own leather belts, to sacrifice as blood-offerings on the funeral
pyre of Patroclus. The River God Scamander, choked with dead bodies and furious at the desecration of his sacred waters, rises in
towering waves, hurling corpses onto the dry land and pursuing Achilles in roaring cataracts. Achilles is nearly overwhelmed and
drowned by the swirling mud. Hera summons Hephaestus, who unleashes a cosmic inferno that scorches the plain, burns the elms,
willows, and tamarisks, and boils the fish and waters of the sacred river until Scamander begs for mercy.

SCENE 61: THE SWIRLING SHALLOWS OF XANTHUS — THE SLAUGHTER — AFTERNOON

Achilles herded the fleeing Trojans into the silver-whirling eddies of great Scamander. The river roared as they
plunged into the steep streams; the banks echoed all around as they swam hither and thither, whirled in the
eddies like locusts driven into a river by the blast of a fire. Achilles leaned his spear against a tamarisk bush and
leaped into the water with his sword alone, his heart plotting slaughter.

He dragged twelve living youths out of the water, dazed like fawns. He bound their hands behind their backs with their own
well-cut leather belts, and gave them to his comrades to lead to the black ships—blood-ransom for fallen Patroclus.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies

of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"
Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"
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In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
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crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 62: THE ROARING WAVES — SCAMANDER RISES IN FURY — AFTERNOON
Scamander raised his head from the deep pools, speaking in a voice like rushing waters: "Achilles, you surpass
all men in strength and in merciless deeds, for the gods themselves ever defend you! If Zeus has granted you to

destroy all the Trojans, drive them out of my stream and work your ruin on the plain! For my lovely channels
are choked with corpses, and I cannot pour my streams into the salt sea, clogged as I am with the dead, while you
slaughter relentlessly! Slay upon the dry land; cease polluting my waters!"
Achilles leaped into the midst of the river, answering: "So shall it be, Scamander! But I will not cease slaughtering these
arrogant Trojans until I have cooped them within their city and tested Hector face to face!"
The river swelled in boiling fury. Rising in a wall of dark water, shouting to his brother river Simois, Scamander hurled
waves against Achilles' shield, sweeping the sand from beneath his feet. Achilles clutched a great elm tree on the bank, but
the roots tore out and the whole tree crashed into the water. In terror the hero ran across the plain, but the black wave leaped
behind him with a deafening roar, washing over his shoulders and dragging down his knees.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"
Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"
Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between
wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your
flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has
ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"
Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!
Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.
Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of
all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"
Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with
sheets of flame.
Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter
the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
than live to see Troy in ashes!"
Achilles drove his spear through Hector's collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that
his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"

In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no
mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless
ransom!"
Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in
sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"
Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,
wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"
King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
its immortal close.
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crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 63: THE SCORCHED PLAIN — HEPHAESTUS' COSMIC INFERNO — DUSK
Hera shrieked in terror for Achilles, calling upon her son Hephaestus to kindle his fire. Hephaestus unleashed an
apocalyptic conflagration. First the corpses on the plain burned; then the green elms, willows, tamarisks, clover,
and reeds along the banks burst into towering pillars of fire. The eels and fish tumbled in agony through the
boiling whirlpools, tormented by the blast of the cunning smith.
The river hissed and boiled like a kettle of lard on a blazing hearth: "Hephaestus! No god can match your fire! I cease from
fighting! Let godlike Achilles drive the Trojans from their city! What have I to do with strife and mortal quarrels?" Hera
stayed her son's fire, and the boiling waters settled back into their charred beds.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
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Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
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Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,

frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
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Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,
wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles' knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
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the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 22: THE DEATH OF HECTOR & THE DRAGGING OF THE BODY IN THE GATE

The Trojans flee through the Scaean Gates into the city like frightened fawns. Hector alone remains outside, bound by his own sense
of honor and shame before Polydamas. Aged King Priam and Queen Hecuba plead with Hector from the battlements, tearing their
white hair and baring breasts, begging him to come inside. Hector stands firm. Achilles approaches like the blazing war-god. Panic
seizes Hector; he turns and runs. Achilles chases Hector three times around the monumental walls of Troy, past the twin
washing-springs of the Scamander. Zeus weighs the golden scales; Hector’s doom sinks to the house of Hades, and Apollo abandons
him. Athena assumes the shape of Hector’s brother Deiphobus, deceiving Hector into standing his ground. In the fatal duel, Achilles
pierces Hector’s neck through the only opening in his armor. Dying, Hector begs for his body to be returned to his parents for gold;
Achilles sneers that dogs and birds will butcher his flesh. Hector’s dying breath prophesies Achilles’ death by Paris and Apollo at
the Scaean Gates. Achilles strips Hector’s corpse, cuts holes behind his ankle tendons, threads ox-hide thongs through them, ties
Hector to his chariot, and drags the body through the black dust before the weeping eyes of Priam, Hecuba, and Andromache.

SCENE 64: THE WALLS OF TROY — THE PLEAS OF PRIAM AND HECUBA — DAY

The Trojan survivors crowded inside the city, wiping the sweat from their bodies and drinking water. But
Hector’s fatal destiny held him bound fast outside the Scaean Gate and the oak tree. Achilles approached,
blazing like the dog-star Sirius that brings fever to wretched mortals, the bronze of his spear flashing like fire.

Old Priam groaned, beating his head with his hands: "Hector! My son! Do not wait for that man alone, without comrades, lest
you meet your doom beneath the son of Peleus, since he is far the mightier! Come inside the wall, dear child, to save the men
and women of Troy! Pity me, unhappy and wretched, whom the Father will destroy in old age by a cruel fate, having seen my
sons slaughtered, my daughters dragged into slavery, my bridal chambers pillaged, and my infant children dashed without
mercy against the ground in the horror of war! And at the last, the ravening hounds I nurtured at my own tables shall tear my
dead body on my palace threshold!"

His mother Hecuba wept likewise, baring her breast with her hands, crying: "Hector, my child! Revere this breast, and have

pity on me, if ever I gave you the soothing breast! Defend yourself against that monster from within the wall, do not stand to
face him! For if he slays you, never shall I lay you on a bed and mourn you, nor your lovely wife; but far from us beside the
Argive ships the swift hounds will devour you!"
Hector leaned his shield against a buttress, whispering to his proud heart: "Ah me! If I go inside the gate and wall, Polydamas
will be the first to heap reproach upon me, for he urged me to lead the Trojans back to the city on that ruinous night when
Achilles arose! But I would not listen; and now that I have ruined my people by my reckless pride, I feel deep shame before
the Trojan men and the long-robed women of Troy, lest some viler man than I should say: 'Hector, trusting in his own
strength, destroyed the city!' It is far better for me to face Achilles, and either slay him and return, or perish gloriously before
the citadel!"
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
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The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
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Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
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Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
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Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
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enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and

no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
its immortal close.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 65: THE CIRCUIT OF THE WALLS — THE PURSUIT & ATHENA'S TRICK — AFTERNOON

When Achilles drew near, shaking the Pelian ash spear over his right shoulder, trembling seized Hector. He could
hold his ground no longer, but fled in terror past the watchtower, past the wind-swept fig-tree, along the
wagon-track beneath the wall. Three times they ran at full speed around the city of Priam with flying feet. A
brave man ran ahead, but an infinitely mightier warrior pursued him swiftly—for it was not for a sacrificial
beast or ox-hide shield they ran, but for the life of horse-taming Hector.
For the fourth time they reached the springs. The Father hung out his golden scales and set in them two lots of death: Hector's
lot sank down to the realm of Hades. Phoebus Apollo abandoned him.
Athena came to Hector's side in the likeness of his brother Deiphobus: "Dear brother, truly swift Achilles presses you hard!
Come, let us stand our ground together and ward him off with our spears!" Hector rejoiced, believing his brother had braved
the battle to stand with him.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above

the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"
Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"
Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between
wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your
flesh!"
In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has
ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"
Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!
Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you

have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.
Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of
all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"
Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with
sheets of flame.
Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter
the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
than live to see Troy in ashes!"
Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that
his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"
In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no
mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless
ransom!"
Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in
sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"
Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,

wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus' son sweeps the field!"
King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles' knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
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Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
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Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
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shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 66: THE FATAL DUEL & THE DESECRATION IN THE DUST — SUNSET
Hector turned to Achilles: "No longer will I fly from you, son of Peleus! Now my heart bids me stand and face
you, to slay or be slain! But come, let us swear an oath before the gods: if Zeus grants me to outlast you and strip
your life, I will return your body to the Achaeans, once I have taken your glorious armor! Do you likewise to
me!"
Achilles glared at him with murderous fury: "Hector, talked-of fool, speak not to me of covenants! As there are no faithful
covenants between lions and men, and as wolves and lambs have no harmony of heart, but hate each other unceasingly: so
between you and me there can be no friendship, nor shall any oaths exist between us, until one of us falls and sates with his
blood Ares, the warrior of the tough shield! Call up all your skill with the spear; for now Pallas Athena shall subdue you
beneath my bronze!"
Achilles hurled his long-shadowed spear, but Hector ducked, and the bronze flew over and stuck in the earth; Athena plucked
it up invisibly and gave it back to Achilles. Hector hurled his spear, striking the center of Achilles' shield, but the divine
metal threw it off! Turning to ask Deiphobus for a second spear, Hector saw no one beside him; the plain was empty. Hector
understood.
Hector drew his great sword: "Ah, truly the gods have summoned me to death! Deiphobus is inside the wall, and Athena has
deceived me! Death stands close beside me, and there is no escape! But let me not perish without a struggle, nor ingloriously,
but having done some great deed that men yet unborn shall hear of!"
Hector swept forward like a high-soaring eagle swooping from dark clouds upon a timid hare. Achilles charged to meet him,
covering his chest with his marvelous shield, his four-horned helmet shaking its golden crest. Scanning Hector's body,
Achilles saw that the divine armor Hector had stripped from Patroclus covered him everywhere—except where the
collarbones join the neck at the throat, where life is cut off most swiftly. There godlike Achilles drove his spear; the heavy
bronze point went clean through the soft neck, yet severed not the windpipe, so that Hector could still speak.

Hector whispered through his blood: "I entreat you by your life, by your knees, by your parents: do not leave me for the dogs
to devour by the ships of the Achaeans! Accept bronze and gold in abundance, which my father and noble mother will give
you, and give my body back to my home, that the Trojans and Trojan wives may give me my share of fire in death!"
Achilles sneered with flashing teeth: "Dog! Entreat me not by knees or parents! Would that my own fury and heart would
drive me to carve your flesh and eat it raw for the evils you have done me! There is no man alive who can keep the dogs from
your head—not even if they bring ten and twenty times your ransom, not even if Dardanian Priam bids them weigh your body
in gold! Your noble mother shall never lay you upon a bier and mourn the son she bore; but dogs and birds of prey shall tear
your flesh to pieces!"
Hector spoke with his dying gasp: "I know you well, and foresee what will be; I was not fated to persuade you, for your heart
within your breast is made of iron! Take heed now, lest I bring upon you the wrath of the gods, on that day when Paris and
Phoebus Apollo shall destroy you, valiant though you are, at the Scaean Gate!" Death enveloped his eyes and nostrils; his
soul flew to Hades, weeping its lot.
Achilles stripped the blood-stained armor from Hector’s shoulders. Other Achaeans ran up, marvelling at Hector’s size and
handsome form, and each man stabbed his spear into the dead body, laughing: "Ha! Hector is far softer to touch now than
when he set fire to our ships!"
Then Achilles devised shameful treatment for the dead hero. He slit the tendons behind both ankles from heel to ankle-joint,
threaded ox-hide thongs through them, and tied them to his chariot, leaving the head to drag along the ground. He mounted
the car, lifted the glorious spoils, and lashed the horses. The two steeds flew eagerly across the sand. A thick cloud of black
dust rose from the dragged body; the dark hair was swept out on either side, and the handsome head rolled in the dirt. Upon
the walls of Troy, Queen Hecuba shrieked and tore her veil, King Priam groaned in agony, and Princess Andromache,
dropping her shuttle at the loom, ran to the ramparts and fainted into the arms of her maidens as she saw her husband dragged
behind the flying wheels toward the hollow ships of the Achaeans.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient

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The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
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Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
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In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
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Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
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The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
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the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
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Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
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Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter
the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
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Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in
sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"
Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,
wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.
Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel

of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
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Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
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its immortal close.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 23: THE FUNERAL GAMES OF PATROCLUS & THE CHARIOT RACE

Achilles and the Myrmidons mourn Patroclus, driving their chariots three times around the bier. That night, the ghost of Patroclus
appears to the sleeping Achilles, begging for swift burial so his soul may pass the gates of Hades, and requesting that their bones be
laid together in a single golden urn. At dawn, a colossal pyre a hundred feet square is built from mountain timber. Achilles slays
sheep, oxen, four horses, two hunting hounds, and twelve noble Trojan captives upon the pyre, cutting off his golden curls as an
offering. Boreas and Zephyrus blow all night, consuming the pyre in roaring flames. The next day, Achilles hosts the funeral games:
Diomedes wins the chariot race through Athena's aid; Epeus wins the boxing; Great Ajax and Odysseus wrestle to a draw;
Odysseus wins the footrace; and Agamemnon is awarded the spear-throwing prize without contest out of honor.

SCENE 67: THE SHORE OF THE SOUNDING SEA — GHOST OF PATROCLUS — NIGHT

Achilles lay sleeping upon the seashore, exhausted from his grief and battle. Down came the phantom of unhappy
Patroclus, like him in size, lovely eyes, and voice, and wearing the same garments. He stood above Achilles' head.

The ghost spoke: "You sleep, Achilles, and have forgotten me! In my life you were never neglectful of me, but now in death!
Bury me in all haste, that I may pass within the gates of Hades! The spirits of the dead drive me away and will not permit me
to cross the river! And lay this in your heart: do not lay my bones apart from yours, Achilles, but together, as we were reared
in your halls, in the golden two-handled urn given to you by your noble mother!"

Achilles reached out his arms to embrace him, but caught nothing; like vapor the spirit vanished beneath the earth with a thin
cry. Achilles leaped up clapping his hands: "Ah! Truly even in the house of Hades there is a spirit and phantom, though there
is no bodily heart within it!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
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Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
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The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
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Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
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The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"

In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless ransom!"

Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"

Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"

The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn, wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.

Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my

eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"

Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles' knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
its immortal close.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 68: THE FUNERAL PYRE OF PATROCLUS — THE SACRIFICE — MORNING

They built a pyre a hundred feet on either side. Upon it they laid fat sheep, curved-horned cattle, jars of honey
and oil, four neck-arching horses, two faithful watchdogs, and twelve noble sons of the great-hearted Trojans,
whom Achilles slew with his ruthless bronze blade. The winds Boreas and Zephyrus blew in fury all through the
night, feeding the roaring conflagration.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos
aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.
Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"
Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps
from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside
the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us
clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"
Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between
wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your
flesh!"
In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father
Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector
was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has
ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged
of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for
mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may
bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."
Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!
Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.
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Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
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The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
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shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
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SCENE 69: THE RUNNING TRACK & WRESTLING RING — THE GAMES — DAY
Achilles held the host and seated them in a wide ring, setting out prizes from his ships: cauldrons, tripods,
horses, mules, and fair-girdled women. Diomedes won the thrilling chariot race; Epeus knocked out Euryalus in
boxing; Telamonian Ajax and Odysseus locked in a titanic wrestling match until Achilles declared them equal
champions, dividing the prizes.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
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Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps

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die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never

seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find
the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
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BOOK 24: PRIAM RANSOMS THE BODY OF HECTOR & THE SHARED TEARS OF KING

For twelve days Achilles mourns Patroclus, dragging Hector's corpse three times around the tomb each morning; Apollo preserves
the body unblemished with his golden aegis. The gods pity Hector and decree that Achilles must surrender the body. Iris visits
Priam; despite Hecuba's terror, the aged king fills his wagon with boundless treasures and sets forth into the dark night. Hermes
guides Priam invisibly through the Greek sentries into Achilles' tent. In the supreme emotional climax of Western literature, Priam
falls to his knees, grasping Achilles' knees and kissing the terrible hands that slew fifty of his sons. Achilles is moved to tears,
remembering his own aged father Peleus and fallen Patroclus. The two mortal enemies weep together. Achilles grants the ransom,
has Hector's body washed and anointed in secret, shares a meal with Priam, and pledges an eleven-day armistice. Priam returns to
Troy with Hector's body at dawn. Andromache, Hecuba, and Helen deliver their immortal laments, and the epic concludes with the
solemn burning and burial of Hector, tamer of horses.

SCENE 70: THE MIDNIGHT TENT — PRIAM AT THE FEET OF ACHILLES — MIDNIGHT

Hermes opened the heavy bolted door and departed to Olympus. Great King Priam entered unnoticed, stepped
forward, and threw his arms around the knees of Achilles, kissing the terrible, man-slaying hands that had
slaughtered so many of his sons. Achilles sat in astonishment, and his companions Automedon and Alcimus
looked upon the aged king with dread awe, as when a homicide flees his fatherland and enters a rich man's
house.

Priam looked up into Achilles' eyes: "Remember your father, godlike Achilles, a man of my own years, on the sad threshold
of old age! Perhaps even now his neighbors hem him in with war, and there is no one to keep ruin from his halls! Yet he,
hearing that you are still alive, rejoices in his heart and hopes every day to see his beloved son returning from Troy! But I am
utterly wretched! I sired fifty sons in wide Troy, and most of them furious Ares has cut down! And he who was the only one
left to me, who guarded our city and its people—Hector—him you slew only days ago as he fought for his fatherland! For his
sake I have come to the ships of the Achaeans, to ransom him from your hands, bringing boundless treasure! Revere the gods,
Achilles, and have pity on me, remembering your own father! For I am more pitiable than any man on earth: I have endured
what no mortal man has ever endured—to lift to my lips the hands of the man who slew my children!"

He spoke, and stirred in Achilles the desire to weep for his father. Achilles took the old man by the hand and gently pushed
him back. The two wept together: Priam huddled at Achilles' feet wept bitter tears for man-slaying Hector, and Achilles wept
for his own father Peleus, and now again for Patroclus; and the sound of their weeping filled the tent.
The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the
Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient
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Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let
Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the
true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"
The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies
of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones
down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"
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the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles
than live to see Troy in ashes!"
Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that
his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"
In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no
mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless
ransom!"
Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for
Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in

sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"
Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child
an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"
The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn,
wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.

Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel
of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today
the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"
King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my
eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"
Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never
seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds!
Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"
Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the
enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing
for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and
no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"
Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson
robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find

the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."
Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart
was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."
The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached
its immortal close.
The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms
crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector
shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"
The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 71: THE SHARED MEAL & THE ELEVEN-DAY TRUCE — PRE-DAWN
Achilles rose and lifted the old king by the hand, pitying his white head and white beard: "Ah, unhappy man!
Truly many sorrows have you endured in your heart! How did you dare come alone to the ships of the Achaeans,
into the eyes of that man who slew so many of your noble sons? Your heart is made of iron! But come, sit upon a
chair, and let us let our sorrows lie quiet in our hearts, for chilling lamentation profits nothing! For so the gods
have spun the thread of life for wretched mortals: that we should live in agony, while they themselves are free
from care! Two jars stand on the floor of Zeus, filled with gifts he gives: one of evils, and the other of blessings.
The man to whom Zeus gives a mingled lot meets now with evil and now with good; but he to whom he gives only
evil is driven across the sacred earth by ravenous despair, honored neither by gods nor mortals!"

Achilles went outside with his squires. They unloaded the boundless ransom from Priam’s wagon, leaving two tunics and a
cloak to cover Hector’s body. Achilles had handmaids wash and anoint the body with sweet oil in secret, lifting Hector with
his own hands onto a bier, and prayed to Patroclus in Hades not to be angry that he had surrendered noble Hector.
Returning inside, Achilles asked: "How many days do you require to bury noble Hector, King Priam? For so long I will hold
back the Achaean host and stay the battle."
Priam answered: "Nine days we would mourn him in our halls, and on the tenth bury him and feast the people; on the
eleventh build a mound over him, and on the twelfth we will fight, if fight we must!" Achilles clasped Priam’s right wrist,
that he might have no fear in his heart.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls!

Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you
have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to
remember night and day through my tears!"
The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar,
frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon
the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of
Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.
Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of
all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"
Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my
waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with
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eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old
eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"
Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will
die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn
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Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers.
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robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.
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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of
the Western world drew to its solemn close.
SCENE 72: SACRED ILIUM — THE THREE LAMENTS & THE BURNING OF HECTOR — DAY
Priam drove the wagon bearing Hector’s body into Troy as the morning broke. The citizens wept aloud, meeting
them at the gates. They carried Hector into the royal palace, laying him upon a carved bed, and singers took
their place beside him, chanting dirges.
Andromache held his head in her hands: "Husband, you have perished young, leaving me a widow in your halls, and our child
an infant whom you and I in our misery bore! He will never reach manhood, for before that our city will be sacked from its
high towers! For you are dead, who watched over her and kept safe her gentle wives and little children! And you, my child,
will either go with me to a foreign land to labor at unseemly tasks for a harsh master, or some Achaean will seize you by the
hand and hurl you from our high wall to a grim death, in wrath because Hector slew his brother, father, or son! For not gentle
was your father in the bitter combat! Therefore the people mourn you through the city, Hector, and you have left unutterable
weeping and sorrow to your parents! But to me above all are left bitter agonies; for in your death you did not reach out your
hands to me from your bed, nor speak some memorable word that I might remember night and day through my tears!"
Helen stepped forward, weeping: "Hector, dearest to my heart of all my brothers-in-law! Twenty years have passed since I left
my native land and followed Alexandros to Troy; yet never in all those years did I hear an evil or reproachful word from your
lips! If anyone reproached me in the palace—your brothers, your sisters, or your mother—you always restrained them with
your gentle heart and soothing words! Therefore I weep for you and for myself in my misery, for no one else in wide Troy is
left to be gentle or kind to me, but all men shudder at me as I pass!"
For nine days they gathered wood from Mount Ida. On the tenth day they carried glorious Hector out with tears, placed him
upon the summit of the pyre, and set it ablaze with fire.
At dawn, they quenched the dying embers with dark wine. His brothers and comrades gathered his white bones, weeping, and
wrapped them in soft purple cloths. They laid the bones in a golden chest, placed it in a hollow grave, covered it with great

stones, and heaped a monumental barrow above it. Having raised the mound, they gathered in the palace of King Priam and
celebrated a glorious funeral feast.
H o m e r i c R h a p s o d e (N a r r a t o r) s a i d , " S u c h w a s t h e b u r i a l o f H e c t o r , t a m e r o f h o r s e s . kÂ 1ÀÀ¿´¬¼¿¹¿ . "

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above
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